

READ ANYONE INSTANTLY

The Psychology of Hidden Intentions, Micro-Signals and Human Masks

by LEGENDCHIL

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INTRODUCTION

Why No One Shows You Who They Are

Everyone you cross paths with presents a version of themselves. The friendly colleague, the helpful neighbour, the person who texts you at three in the morning saying they've never felt this way.

Most people accept that version without questioning it. Then, one day, the mask slips — and they're left thinking: "How did I not see it?"

You saw it. You just didn't know what you were looking at.

WHAT THIS GUIDE IS

A practical method, in four parts, built on decades of psychology research — from Paul Ekman to Robert Cialdini, from Joe Navarro to John Gottman:

— **Part I — Read.** How to observe face, body, voice, words, messages and groups. The foundation of everything.

— **Part II — The Predators.** Why they choose you, and the tactics of people who want to use you: love bombing, isolation, gaslighting, triangulation, intermittent reinforcement, the comeback.

— **Part III — Power.** Where manipulation happens: influence, work, family, friendships, interest and betrayal.

— **Part IV — Defence.** What to say, which boundaries to set, how to leave, how to help someone who's trapped, how to train.

HOW EACH CHAPTER IS BUILT

— **A real case** — a documented story that runs through the chapter.

— **The ideas and the studies that prove them** — what research found, and what it means for you.

— **The signs** — what to look for, concretely.

— **Use this** — one way to protect yourself and one way to help someone else.

— **Today's training** — ten minutes in the real world.

— **An episode** — see below.

INÊS'S STORY

At the end of each chapter you'll find a short episode of a story. Inês is 27 and has just moved to Lisbon. You'll follow her for a year.

The story is fiction. The cases and studies in the book are real.

I won't explain the episodes to you. You'll read them the way you'd read someone's life: with nice people, ordinary days and details that seem unimportant. At the end of each part there's a page for you to write down what you think. At the end of the book, there's the answer.

Just one rule: **read the episodes with what you learned in the chapter — not with what you feel about the characters.**

WHAT THIS GUIDE ISN'T

It isn't a lie-detecting machine. There is no gesture, expression or pause that, on its own, proves someone is lying or has bad intentions. Anyone who tells you otherwise is selling you a trick.

What exists are **patterns**: changes from a person's normal, repeated, tied to specific topics, that make sense in context. That's what you're going to learn to see.

HOW TO USE THIS GUIDE

1. Read Part I first. Everything else depends on it.
2. Do the training. Ten minutes a day is enough.

3. Use what you learn to **protect yourself and decide better** — not to control, humiliate or label others.

Be more alert. Not more suspicious.

PART I

Read

The method. Before you can spot predators, you have to learn to see.

CHAPTER

01

The Three Masks and the Gap

In 2013, Tyler Shultz was 22 and had just joined the most talked-about company in the world: Theranos. Its founder, Elizabeth Holmes, promised hundreds of lab tests from a single drop of blood.

Investors had put almost a billion dollars into it. Its board included former US cabinet secretaries — among them Tyler's grandfather.

Everyone believed. But Tyler worked in the lab. And in the lab he saw something no one else saw: **the results didn't add up.**

This chapter is about what Tyler saw — and why so many brilliant people didn't see the same thing.

EVERYONE WEARS A MASK

Let's start with the least obvious part: masks aren't a manipulator thing. They're a human thing.

The sociologist Erving Goffman compared social life to a theatre: there's a **stage**, where we perform, and there's **backstage**, where the performance stops (Goffman, 1959). It isn't hypocrisy. It's social survival.

And lying is part of the performance — more than we think. In a study where 147 people logged every lie they told in a diary, the average was **one to two lies a day**, almost all of them small (DePaulo et al., 1996). In other words: if everyone lies a little every day, everyone wears a mask. You're not looking for *who* has a mask — you're looking for *who uses it against you*.

So the useful question is never “does this person wear a mask?”. It's: **“how far is the mask from the face?”**

THE THREE LAYERS

— **Public Mask** — what they show strangers. Polished, rehearsed. The “CV” version.

— **Social Mask** — what they show friends and colleagues. Looser, still filtered.

— **Private Face** — real fears, desires and ambitions. It only appears with time, intimacy or pressure.

FIG. 01

The 3 masks



The mask slips for microseconds. That's when you read.

Holmes's **Public Mask** was flawless: the Steve Jobs black turtleneck, the deep voice, the unblinking stare, the story of the genius who dropped out of college at 19.

Her **Social Mask** was the one she showed the powerful men on her board: attentive, loyal, admiring.

Her **Private Face** was in the lab. And that's where Tyler was.

WHY THIS MATTERS

Think you would have noticed? Probably not.

When **206 studies** on lie detection were pooled, with more than 24,000 people judging, the accuracy rate was **54%** — barely better than flipping a coin (Bond & DePaulo, 2006). Worse: we catch truths far better than lies. The brain is built to believe.

That isn't a flaw — it's what lets us live in society. But anyone who knows how to build a good mask is counting on it.

What this means for you is simple: **your gut isn't enough.** You need a method — and that method is the gap, coming up next.

Myth: "liars avoid eye contact." When 158 supposed signs of lying were reviewed, most of them — gaze included — showed a weak link or none at all with lying (DePaulo et al., 2003). There's no single gesture that gives a liar away. There are patterns.

The cabinet secretaries on the Theranos board weren't naive. They were just judging **the wrong layer**.

THE GAP IS THE SIGNAL

Don't try to guess someone's Private Face. Look for the **gap**: the distance between what a person says they are and what they repeatedly do.

Why "repeatedly"? Because people aren't consistent in general — they're consistent in their **"if… then…" patterns**: *if* they're contradicted, *then* they attack; *if* asked for details, *then* they change the subject (Mischel & Shoda, 1995). That's where the real person lives. It proves the core rule of this book: **a moment says nothing; a pattern says almost everything.**

Examples of gaps:

— **Says they value respect** — but interrupts everyone.

— **Says they're transparent** — but tenses up at simple questions.

— **Says they don't care about money** — but talks about prices in every conversation.

— **Says they're fiercely loyal** — but trashes every old friend.

At Theranos the gap was huge: the promise was “hundreds of tests on our machine”; the reality, later revealed by the Wall Street Journal, was that the machine ran only a small fraction of them. Tyler saw the gap because he looked at what repeated every day.

> *A single gap is noise. A gap that repeats is information.*

THREE MASKS TO RECOGNISE

— **The Victim Mask** — everything happens to them, nothing is ever their fault. *It asks for your empathy.*

— **The Competence Mask** — huge promises, zero detail. *It asks for your trust.*

— **The Loyalty Mask** — “you're like a brother to me” after two weeks. *It asks for access.*

Holmes wore the **Competence** mask. The tell: **the more specific your question, the vaguer the answer.**

And **Loyalty** is the most dangerous, because it turns people against whoever doubts. When Tyler told his grandfather what he was seeing, he was rebuked. His grandfather sided with Holmes.

> *People who work hard to convince you of who they are rarely are.*

THE MOMENT THE MASK SLIPS

Keeping a mask on is tiring. And when the mind is busy, control fails.

In a study with 55 police officers, asking suspects to tell their story **backwards** — a task that overloads the brain — raised lie detection from **46% to 58%** (Vrij et al., 2008). The lesson: you don't need to be a detective. You just need to notice what happens when someone's mind is busy.

In real life, three moments do the same thing:

— **Stress** — no energy left to perform.

— **Surprise** — no time to prepare the answer.

— **Frustration** — they lost, were contradicted, didn't get what they wanted.

At Theranos, that moment came when Tyler started asking questions. The company didn't answer with data. **It answered with lawyers.**

You don't need to provoke these moments. Just notice them when they happen. How someone treats the waiter who got their order wrong tells you more than ten pleasant dinners with you.

WHAT THE GAP IS NOT

— **A mask isn't a lie.** Everyone has a stage and a backstage.

— **A gap can be insecurity.** The pattern tells you *where* to look, not *why*.

— **Don't diagnose.** The goal is to decide how much access someone has earned.

HOW IT ENDED

In 2015, the Wall Street Journal exposed Theranos. Tyler was one of the sources. The company collapsed. In 2022, Holmes was convicted of fraud and later sentenced to more than 11 years in prison.

Tyler had no special gift. He did one thing: **he compared what he was told with what he saw, over and over** — and trusted the pattern, not the mask.

That's what you're going to learn to do.

But to see a gap, you first need to know what someone's *normal* is. Without that, you'll see lies where there are only nerves. That's where Chapter 2 begins.

USE THIS

PROTECT YOURSELF	Before you give someone new access — money, secrets, your home — pick one thing they say they are and wait for three behaviours that confirm it.
HELP SOMEONE	If someone close to you is dazzled by a new person, don't attack the mask. Ask: "And how does he react when things go wrong?"

> *Don't read the person. Read the distance between what they say and what they do.*

TODAY'S PRACTICE

Pick someone you talk to a lot. Write down three things they say about themselves. For one week, log only behaviours that confirm or contradict each one. At the end: where's the gap?

EPISODE 1 · ARRIVAL

Inês is 27 and arrived in Lisbon on a Sunday night with a car full of boxes. New job at a communications agency, a one-bedroom flat in Arroios, no friends in the city. Her four-year relationship had ended in June.

On Monday, the first person to talk to her is Sofia, from the same team. She shows her the coffee machine, lends her a phone charger, tells her where you can eat well for under ten euros. “Everyone here is nice, but there's a lot of talking behind backs. I stay out of it.” At lunch, between the dish of the day and dessert, she mentions that Marco, across the open-plan office, “had a serious problem with the boss — but that stays between us.” Before they pay, she asks: “And you, did you come on your own? Boyfriend back in Porto?”

On Thursday, Inês has her first date with Daniel, whom she met on an app. He'd warned her: “I'm very punctual.” He arrives twenty minutes late, apologising — the metro stopped at Alameda. He talks fast, laughs at himself, looks more at his glass than at her.

The neighbour next door is called Rui. Early forties, quiet. On Friday they pass on the stairs and he asks which agency she works at. She tells him. “Ah,” he says. “I know it.” And he goes up.

That night, sitting on the floor among the boxes, Inês thinks Lisbon might not be so hard after all. She already has a friend.

Who would you trust?

CHAPTER

02

The Baseline: Each Person's Normal

Perugia, Italy, November 2007. Meredith Kercher, a British student, is found dead in her room. Her housemate, the American Amanda Knox, is 20.

In the days that follow, police and newspapers fixate on her behaviour. According to police testimony, she did stretches and cartwheels at the station. She was photographed kissing her boyfriend outside the house where the crime happened. She didn't cry "the way she should have".

To a lot of people, that was guilt. Amanda Knox was convicted in 2009.

In 2015, Italy's Supreme Court definitively acquitted her. The killer was another man, Rudy Guede, convicted years earlier. Knox's "strange" behaviour proved nothing — it was just how a 20-year-old, alone in a foreign country and in shock, behaved.

The mistake of those who judged her was simple: **they compared her to what they would have done, not to her own normal.**

THE GESTURE SAYS NOTHING. THE CHANGE DOES.

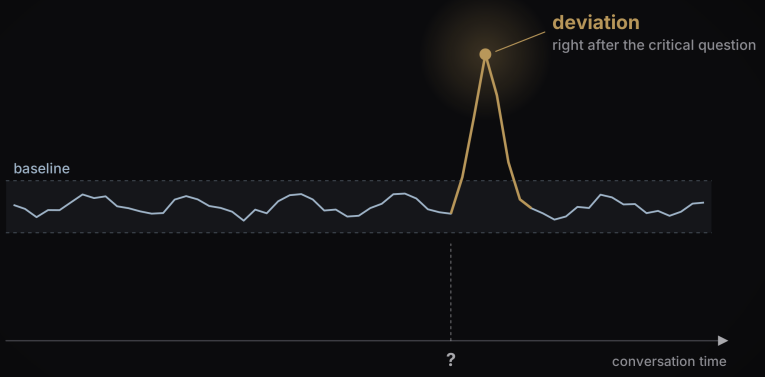
Crossed arms don't mean defensiveness. Looking away doesn't mean lying. Touching your nose means nothing.

This isn't opinion. As you saw in Chapter 1, when 158 supposed signs of lying were reviewed, most showed a weak link or none at all with lying (DePaulo et al., 2003). Some people cross their arms because they're cold. Some avoid eye contact out of shyness, culture or neurodivergence.

What gives someone away isn't the gesture. It's the **change** from that person's normal. That normal is called the **baseline**.

FIG. 02

The baseline



Don't read the signal. Read the change.

WHAT THE BASELINE IS

It's how a person behaves when they're relaxed and under no pressure. Watch six channels:

- **Pace of speech** — fast, slow, with pauses?
- **Tone of voice** — deep, high, varied or flat?
- **Eye contact** — constant, intermittent, rare?
- **Hands** — lots of gestures, still, fiddling with objects?
- **Posture** — open, closed, leaning in?
- **Response time** — answers straight away or thinks first?

Only once you know this can you spot deviations. Without a baseline, you're doing what was done to Amanda Knox: comparing the person to yourself.

WHY THIS MATTERS

The psychologist Paul Ekman named this mistake in 1985: the **Othello error** (Ekman, 1985). In Shakespeare's play, Othello accuses his wife, Desdemona, of betraying him. She cries and denies it — and her tears, which were fear of not being believed, look to him like proof of guilt. Othello kills her. She was innocent.

What Ekman realised is that **an honest person under suspicion looks nervous** — and the nervousness of truth looks just like the nervousness of a lie. If you don't know the baseline, you'll confuse the two.

In other words: without a baseline, you won't just miss lies. You'll **accuse innocent people**. And an unfair accusation destroys a relationship as fast as a betrayal.

HOW TO ESTABLISH A BASELINE

1. **Start with neutral questions.** How was the weekend, where are they from, what did they do today. Without pressure, the normal shows up.
2. **Observe for at least 3 to 5 minutes.** One minute isn't enough.
3. **Consider the context.** No one is at baseline in a job interview — they're nervous by definition.
4. **Repeat over time.** The baseline of someone you've known for months is worth far more than a stranger's.

THE DEVIATIONS THAT MATTER

With the baseline in hand, look for **sudden changes tied to a specific topic**:

— **The voice rises half a tone** on one subject.

— **Normally quick answers slow down** on one question.

— **Normally active hands go still** all of a sudden.

— **Normally natural eye contact turns fixed** and rigid.

— **Long explanations appear** where there used to be short answers.

The key word is *topic*. The same 2003 review found that cues become more visible when the person is **highly motivated** and when the lie is about **something wrong they did** (DePaulo et al., 2003). So a deviation that always shows up on the same subject is worth more than ten scattered ones.

> *A change is a question, not an answer. It tells you where to look — not what's there.*

THE RULE OF THREE

— **One deviation** — could be coincidence.

— **Two at the same moment** — worth your attention.

— **Three tied to the same topic** — that's a pattern.

That's when it's worth asking more questions — calmly, without accusing. It's Chapter 1's rule applied to the body: a moment says nothing; a pattern says almost everything.

If the Perugia police had used this rule, they'd have seen that Knox's behaviour was strange *across the board* — not on one topic. That's not a sign of lying. It's a sign of shock.

Now that you know what normal is, you need to know where to look first. The place people try hardest to control — and where slips last the shortest — is the face. That's Chapter 3.

USE THIS

PROTECT YOURSELF	Before an important conversation — a deal, an interview, a date — spend the first minutes on neutral topics. It isn't small talk: it's calibration.
HELP SOMEONE	If someone close seems "different", compare them to their normal, not yours. Quieter, fewer messages, less laughter: a shift in a friend's baseline can be the first sign they need help and can't say so.

> *Before you read someone, learn their normal. Without it, you're only reading yourself.*

TODAY'S PRACTICE

In your next conversation with someone you know well, pick a single channel — say, the hands. For five minutes of small talk, watch only that. Then move to a more sensitive topic and see whether the pattern changes.

EPISODE 2 · MONDAY

The second date with Daniel is at a small restaurant in Alfama. He talks about his younger sister, his job at an architecture firm, a cat he had as a kid. He barely looks her in the eye — not when she asks about the cat, not when he asks for the bill. On the way home, Inês keeps thinking about it.

At Monday's meeting, Sofia is on form: two jokes about the client, an impression of the finance director's accent, everyone laughing. Halfway through, the boss, Marta, says Inês's proposal for the new client "is the best thing this team has produced this month". Sofia picks up her phone. She doesn't speak again until the end of the meeting.

On the way out, she waits for Inês in the corridor. "Congratulations, seriously! Send me the proposal file and I'll polish it so it's even better."

Inês sends it. It's good to have someone on her side.

What stayed with you from this week?

CHAPTER

03

Micro-Signals: Face, Eyes and Mouth

Seattle, the 1990s. Psychologist John Gottman set up an apartment full of cameras that the press nicknamed the "Love Lab". He asked couples to discuss something they disagreed about — and filmed every second.

In one study he followed 124 newlywed couples for six years. From just the **first three minutes** of an argument, he could predict which ones would split (Carrère & Gottman, 1999).

What was he looking for? Not shouting. It was an expression that often lasts less than a second: one corner of the lip rising while the other person speaks. **Contempt.** In the books he wrote later, Gottman describes it as the strongest sign of a relationship heading for the end.

THE FACE IS WHERE WE CONTROL OURSELVES MOST

The face is the part of the body people try hardest to control — and so it's where slips are most revealing when they happen.

The basic expressions are universal. In the 1960s and 70s, Paul Ekman travelled to Papua New Guinea and showed photos of faces to members of the Fore people, who had almost no contact with the West. They recognised the same emotions Americans did (Ekman & Friesen, 1971). Ekman later added **contempt** to the list (Ekman & Friesen, 1986).

In other words: you don't need to know someone's culture to read their face. But mind the limit — **the face shows an emotion, not the reason for it.** Fear can be guilt. Or fear that you won't believe the truth (remember the Othello error from Chapter 2).

FIG. 03

SOURCE: Paul Ekman & W. Friesen (1971; contempt: 1986)

Ekman's 7 expressions



They last under half a second. Only contempt is one-sided.

THE SEVEN EXPRESSIONS

— **Contempt** — only one corner of the lip rises. The only one-sided expression.

— **Disgust** — wrinkled nose, raised upper lip. Rejection of an idea, person or offer.

— **Fear** — brows raised and pulled together, eyes wide, lips stretched.

— **Anger** — brows down and together, hard stare, lips pressed.

— **Surprise** — brows raised, mouth open. It's brief; surprise that lingers is often staged.

— **Sadness** — inner corners of the brows rise, corners of the mouth drop.

— **Joy** — a genuine smile involves the eyes.

Of these, **contempt** matters most. Anger passes. Sadness passes. Contempt means the other person feels *above* you — which is why Gottman saw it as the beginning of the end.

THE FAKE SMILE

In 1862, the French physician Guillaume Duchenne stimulated volunteers' facial muscles with electricity and noticed something: a real smile doesn't use only the mouth. It activates a muscle around the eyes that's hard to move on purpose. More than a century later, Ekman and colleagues named it the **Duchenne smile** and showed that it appears mainly with genuine enjoyment (Ekman, Davidson & Friesen, 1990).

In practice:

— **Genuine smile** — crow's feet at the eyes, the cheeks lift.

— **Social smile** — only the mouth moves. It appears too fast, stays too long and switches off abruptly.

A social smile isn't a lie — we use it dozens of times a day. But a *mouth-only* smile the moment someone says "I'm so happy for you" is information.

EYES AND MOUTH

— **Blinking more** — tends to rise under mental load or stress. Compare with the baseline.

— **Staring too hard** — some people know "liars look away" and overcorrect. A rigid, unblinking stare is also a deviation.

— **Eyes closing for longer** — a brief block when they hear something unpleasant.

— **Lips pressed** until they almost disappear — something isn't being said.

— **Covering the mouth** while speaking.

WHY THIS MATTERS — AND ITS LIMIT

You may have heard of **micro-expressions**: expressions so fast they're barely visible. They exist, but they're rare. When Stephen Porter and Leanne ten Brinke analysed around 700 genuine and faked expressions in high-pressure situations, only **2%** were micro-expressions (Porter & ten Brinke, 2008).

That means two things. First: you won't catch liars by staring at faces waiting for a flash. Second, and more important: the face matters mostly as one piece of a **pattern** — alongside the baseline, the words and the context.

INCONGRUENCE: THE STRONGEST SIGNAL

What matters most isn't a single expression — it's **incongruence** between face and words:

- They say *"I'm so happy for you"* — and for an instant, contempt.
- They say *"yes"* — while shaking their head.
- They say *"I don't mind"* — with pressed lips.

When words and face disagree, the face is usually closer to the truth. That's what Gottman saw in his couples: the words were polite. The faces weren't.

> *The face shows what someone feels. It doesn't tell you why. For that you need context and questions.*

People train their faces. Almost nobody trains the rest of the body — which is why, in Chapter 4, we go all the way down to the feet.

USE THIS

PROTECT YOURSELF	When what you're hearing sounds too good, watch the face in the instant right after the sentence. Contempt or a mouth-only smile is a reason to slow down.
HELP SOMEONE	A flash of sadness or fear on a friend who says “I'm fine” is an invitation. Don't contradict them — ask again, calmly: “No, really. How are you?”

TODAY'S PRACTICE

Watch two minutes of an interview or debate with the sound off. Note the expressions you see. Then turn the sound on and check whether the words match what the face showed.

EPISODE 3 · SINTRA

Friday evening, Inês shows Sofia the photos from her weekend in Sintra with Daniel. In one, the two of them are laughing outside the Quinta da Regaleira.

Sofia smiles — a quick, crooked smile — and swipes on. “Cute. He's really handsome.” Two more photos. “He looks like he's had a lot of girlfriends, doesn't he? But you know best. I just want you to be OK.”

That night, Daniel texts: “Loved the weekend. Whenever you want to do it again, say.” Inês stares at the message longer than she expected to. A lot of girlfriends?

Which line from this episode stayed with you?

CHAPTER

04

The Body: Hands, Feet, Posture and Distance

Berlin, 1904. A horse called Hans does arithmetic. His owner, Wilhelm von Osten, a maths teacher, asks him "what's three plus two?" — and Hans taps his hoof five times. He tells the time. He spells words. Crowds gather to watch. A commission of 13 experts examines the case and concludes there's no trick.

Three years later, a young psychologist, Oskar Pfungst, runs a simple experiment. When Hans could **see** the person asking, and that person knew the answer, he was right 89% of the time. When he **couldn't** see the questioner, he was right 6% of the time (Pfungst, 1907).

Hans couldn't do maths. He could read bodies. As he got close to the right number, the questioner tensed up — and on the final tap, relaxed without realising. Hans stopped there.

If a horse can read the human body, so can you.

WHY THIS MATTERS

What Pfungst discovered is the core idea of this chapter: **the body talks even when the person doesn't want it to** — and Hans's questioners didn't even know they were giving cues. Pfungst repeated the experiment with people, playing the "horse" himself, and saw the same thing: at the right number, people lifted their heads slightly without noticing.

And we read these signals fast. In a famous study, Nalini Ambady and Robert Rosenthal showed strangers **silent** videos of teachers lecturing — just 30 seconds of each. The strangers' ratings came out very close to

the ones students gave at the end of the semester, after months of classes (Ambady & Rosenthal, 1993). Even with 6 seconds, the result held.

In other words: you already read bodies — without a method. This chapter gives you the method.

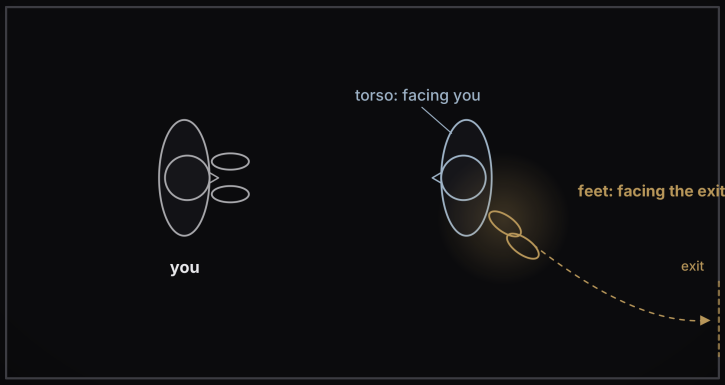
THE DISTANCE RULE

Former FBI agent Joe Navarro, who spent 25 years in interrogation and counterintelligence, popularised a practical rule: **the further a body part is from the face, the less controlled it tends to be** (Navarro, 2008). People train their smile. Almost nobody trains their feet.

FIG. 04

SOURCE: Joe Navarro, What Every Body Is Saying

The feet don't lie



The torso is polite. The feet tell the truth.

THE FEET

- **Feet pointing at the exit** — in a conversation, when the feet turn to the door, the person wants to leave, even if they're smiling.
- **Feet pointing at you** — interest and engagement.

— **Feet that suddenly freeze** — someone who was bouncing a foot and goes still may be reacting to something that was said.

— **Feet tucked under the chair** — withdrawal, discomfort.

THE HANDS

— **Visible, open hands** — tend to go with comfort.

— **Hands that disappear** — into pockets, under the table — *at a specific moment* in the conversation.

— **Self-soothing gestures** — rubbing the neck, touching hair, rubbing the thighs. They don't mean lying; they mean stress.

— **Gestures that arrive late** — a genuine gesture goes with the word. A rehearsed one comes after it.

Notice that none of these works on its own. Always go back to Chapter 2: they only matter as **deviations from baseline**, tied to a topic.

POSTURE AND MIRRORING

— **Leaning in** — interest, or a wish to dominate the space.

— **Leaning back** — distance, evaluation or disinterest.

— **Body turned sideways** — "I'm here, but not completely."

— **Taking up space** — open arms, things spread on the table. Linked to comfort and status.

When two people are in tune, they copy each other without noticing. Tanya Chartrand and John Bargh called it the **chameleon effect**: in one study, when someone discreetly mirrored a participant's posture and gestures, the participant liked them more and found the conversation smoother — without realising they were being mirrored (Chartrand & Bargh, 1999).

That proves two things at once. Natural mirroring is a good sign of connection. And anyone who knows the effect can **use it on purpose** to cre-

ate a false sense of rapport. The difference: natural mirroring has a delay and imperfections; calculated mirroring is too fast and too complete.

DISTANCE AND BOUNDARIES

Everyone has a "bubble" of space. Notice who enters it without asking — a touch on the arm too early, a hand on your back, standing too close.

Entering someone's space and seeing whether they react is a way of **testing boundaries**. And there's a pattern worth gold: people who test small boundaries early tend to test big ones later. You'll come back to this in Chapter 22.

MYTH: "93% OF COMMUNICATION IS NON-VERBAL"

You'll hear this a lot. It comes from Albert Mehrabian's experiments in the 1960s, but those studies were about a very specific case — people saying a single word in a tone that contradicted it. Mehrabian himself warned that the numbers don't apply to communication in general. The body doesn't replace words. **It completes them.**

> *The feet say where someone wants to go. The hands say what they're feeling. The face says what they want you to see.*

The body gives you the feeling. But people also give themselves away in how they speak — and that's even less controlled than you'd think. That's Chapter 5.

USE THIS

PROTECT YOURSELF	Notice who steps into your bubble too early. Respond with one step back, no words. If they step in again, they were testing you — and now you know.
HELP SOMEONE	In a group, notice who has their feet towards the exit and their body pulled in. It's often the person who's uncomfortable and won't say so. One question from you can get them out of there.

TODAY'S PRACTICE

In a café or a meeting, ignore faces. Watch only the feet of three people during a conversation. Guess who wants to leave and who wants to stay — and check against what happens next.

EPISODE 4 · LUNCH

Team lunch at a small tavern behind the office. Sofia sits next to Inês and keeps touching her arm as she talks — “you're really special, you know that?”. Inês shifts her chair a little to reach the bread. A bit later, Sofia leans in again.

At dinner, Daniel is nervous, as always. When Inês says she's tired and would rather call it an early night, he says “of course”, asks for the bill and walks her to the metro.

At her building, Rui is in the entrance chatting with the doorman and smiles at her. Sofia, who'd walked her home, appears at the door to give her back her jacket. Rui suddenly remembers he's left something in his car and goes out.

Who's at ease with whom?

CHAPTER

05

Voice and Words

26 January 1998. The President of the United States, Bill Clinton, looks into the cameras at the White House and says slowly, jabbing his finger: "I did not have sexual relations with that woman, Miss Lewinsky."

Notice three words: **"that woman"**. Monica Lewinsky had worked near him for months. He knew her name — and said it straight after. But first, he spoke of her like a stranger.

Seven months later, Clinton admitted the relationship. The distance had been there from day one. Not in his face. In the **sentence**.

PEOPLE CHOOSE THEIR WORDS. THEY RARELY CHOOSE HOW THEY SAY THEM.

A liar has to do two things at once: **invent the content** and **control the form**. Remember Vrij's study in Chapter 1: when the mind is busy, control fails. In language it's the same — which is why analysing words is often more reliable than analysing the body.

WHY THIS MATTERS

Psychologist James Pennebaker and colleagues asked 287 people to write and talk about topics like abortion — sometimes saying what they believed, sometimes arguing the opposite. Then a computer program analysed only the *form* of the words, ignoring the content (Newman et al., 2003).

The result: the program told liars from truth-tellers **61% to 67%** of the time. Human judges reading the same texts managed **52%** — basically chance. And the liars had a clear pattern:

— **Fewer "I"s** — they distance themselves from the story.

— **More negative words** — tension, discomfort.

— **Fewer words like "but" and "except"** — simpler stories, with less nuance.

In other words: **"that woman"** wasn't an accident. It was exactly the distancing research finds in lies. And here's the important bit: people miss it because they're listening to *what* is said, not *how*.

THE VOICE

— **Pitch rising** — stress and tension tend to push it up.

— **Pace changing** — someone fast who slows on one topic, or the reverse.

— **Pauses before simple answers** — "Where were you last night?" shouldn't need three seconds.

— **Throat-clearing, coughing, swallowing** at specific moments.

— **Volume dropping** at the end of important sentences.

As always: these only count as **deviations from baseline** (Chapter 2).

THE WORDS THAT GIVE PEOPLE AWAY

— **Over-explaining** — truth-tellers answer. Story-builders justify.

— **Honesty claims** — "honestly", "to be fair", "I swear", "why would I lie?". People telling the truth rarely feel the need to announce it.

— **Answering with a question** — "Why are you asking me that?" buys time.

— **Repeating the question** — "Was I with her last night?" also buys time.

— **Distancing** — “that woman”; “the car got scratched” instead of “I scratched the car”. It's Pennebaker's “fewer I's”.

— **Denial without a denial** — asked “Did you take the money?”, answering “I'd never do something like that” instead of “No”.

— **Lopsided detail** — lots of detail on what doesn't matter, little on the critical moment.

— **Attacking the questioner** — “You're always so suspicious of me!” turns the conversation from the question to you.

> *A direct answer to a direct question is rare. When the question is simple and the answer is complicated, something is being managed.*

HOW TO ASK QUESTIONS THAT REVEAL

What works with language is **raising the load** without accusing:

— **Open question** — “Tell me how it went”, instead of “Did you go?”.

— **The story backwards** — from end to start. It's the method from Vrij's study (Chapter 1): invented stories are built in order and are hard to take apart.

— **An unexpected question** about a detail — “What music was playing?”. People who lived it remember, or say “I didn't notice” naturally. People who invented it hesitate.

— **Silence after the answer** — many people fill silence with more than they meant to say.

These days, half of our conversations happen without a voice or a face. They happen in writing — and messages leave traces a conversation doesn't. That's Chapter 6.

USE THIS

PROTECT YOURSELF

When the answer to a simple question is complicated, repeat the question — slowly, word for word, without accusing. People telling the truth answer. People managing a story run out of road.

HELP SOMEONE

The open questions in this chapter aren't only for taking stories apart. With someone going through something hard, they're the gentlest way to help them tell a truth that hurts.

TODAY'S PRACTICE

Next time someone tells you a story, count how often they use words like “honestly”, “actually” or “I swear”. Don't accuse. Just note it. You'll start hearing patterns you used to miss.

EPISODE 5 · THE REPORT

On Tuesday, Marta calls Inês into her office. The client report arrived late and the client complained. “Sofia told me she was waiting on your part.” Inês had sent her part on Friday, at five in the afternoon.

That afternoon, she asks Sofia: “Did you tell Marta the delay was my fault?”

Sofia puts down her mug. “Why are you asking me that? Honestly, Inês... The report went out late, that's all, it happens to everyone. I'd never do something like that to a friend. Least of all you, after everything I've done to help you.”

Inês apologises for asking.

That night, she asks Daniel if he still talks to his ex. “No. It ended because she cheated on me. It hurt, but it's over.”

Who answered the question?

CHAPTER

06

Reading Text Messages

United States, 2012. Manti Te'o is one of the stars of college football at the University of Notre Dame. During the season he tells reporters the story that moves the country: his girlfriend, Lennay Kekua, 22, died of leukaemia in September — on the same day as his grandmother.

In January 2013, the website Deadspin reveals that Lennay Kekua **never existed**. The photos belonged to another woman, who had no idea they were being used. The relationship had happened entirely through messages, social media and calls. The two had never met. The person who created the character, a former schoolmate of Te'o's, later admitted to inventing her.

Te'o wasn't naive. He'd just met someone through one channel only — the written one — which **hides almost everything you learned in the previous chapters**.

WHY THIS MATTERS

By text there's no face, no feet, no tone. Only words — and words can be chosen, revised, deleted.

You'd expect us to lie more in writing. The research says something more interesting. When Jeffrey Hancock and colleagues asked 30 students to log every communication and every lie for a week, the share of conversations containing lies was **37% on the phone**, **27% face to face**, **21% on instant messaging** and **14% by email** (Hancock et al., 2004). The authors' explanation: we lie less where there's a **record**.

That gives you an advantage you don't have in conversation. In messages, words stay written — and what matters most isn't what they say, it's the **pattern**: when they arrive, how they change, what disappears.

THE DIGITAL BASELINE

As with the body (Chapter 2), first learn the normal:

— **How long** do they usually take to reply?

— Do they write **long or short** messages?

— Do they use **emojis**? Which ones?

— **Who usually starts** conversations?

— **What time** do they talk to you?

THE DEVIATIONS THAT MATTER

— **Reply times that change consistently** — from minutes to hours, for weeks. Something has changed.

— **Shrinking messages** — from paragraphs to “ok”, “yeah”, “k”.

— **Usual emojis disappearing** — the emotional temperature drops.

— **Answering only the easy part** — you send three questions, they answer one.

— **New hours** — only talks by day, never at night; or the reverse.

“SEEN” AND SILENCE

Leaving you on read once is nothing. Leaving you on read **as a pattern**, alternating with bursts of attention, is one of the most effective control tactics there is. It's called intermittent reinforcement — you'll see in Chapter 14 why it hooks so hard.

SIGNS OF INTEREST AND WARNING SIGNS

Real interest by text:

— **Asks about you** — doesn't just reply.

— **Remembers** what you said days ago.

— **Starts conversations** without needing anything.

— **Replies in proportion** to what you send.

Warning signs:

— **Intensity too early** — 3 a.m. messages, “I've never felt this way” in week one.

— **Demanding instant replies** — “Why did you take 20 minutes?”

— **Switching channels when things get serious** — “let's talk later”, “not something to put in writing”.

— **Deleting messages**, or preferring disappearing messages for ordinary things. Remember Hancock's study: people who don't want a record have a reason.

— **Rewriting history** — “I never said that”, when it's right there in writing.

In the Te'o case, one signal outweighed all the others: for months, **there was never a video call or a meeting**. There was always a reason — the hospital, an accident, the illness. When someone consistently avoids the one channel that would show their face, the gap (Chapter 1) lives in that silence.

> *In messages, don't read the words. Read the pattern. Words can be chosen. The pattern gives them away.*

So far you've read one person at a time. But you're almost never with just one person. In a group there's an invisible structure of power — and whoever sees it first has the advantage. That's Chapter 7.

USE THIS

PROTECT YOURSELF	Don't reply on the spot to pressure messages (“why did you take so long?”). Reply at your normal pace. Your pace is your baseline — don't let anyone re-write it.
HELP SOMEONE	If a friend shows you a chat and asks “am I overreacting?”, don't argue about one line. Show them the pattern: who starts, who apologises, who demands.

TODAY'S PRACTICE

Open the chat with someone important to you and scroll through the last few weeks. Don't read the content — just look at the rhythm: who starts, how long each of you takes, the length of the messages. The pattern tells you what the words don't.

EPISODE 6 · 23:47

Thursday, 23:47. A message from Sofia:

“I don't want to be mean... but I think I saw Daniel on the app again 👀 Maybe it's nothing. I just thought you should know. Love you lots.”

Two minutes later another one arrives, which Inês only sees in the morning: “This message was deleted.”

Inês asks Daniel, half afraid. He replies twenty minutes later, as he usually does: “I deleted my account the day after I met you. Want to see?” And he sends a screenshot.

That week, Sofia messages her almost every night, late. About work, about life, about Daniel.

What would you do with the 23:47 message?

CHAPTER

07

Reading Any Room in 60 Seconds

Swarthmore College, United States, 1951. A student walks into a room for what he's told is a vision test. Seven other people are already seated. They're shown one line and three lines to compare. Which one is the same length? The answer is obvious.

But one by one, the other seven give the **wrong** answer. Out loud. Completely calm.

The student doesn't know the seven are actors working for psychologist Solomon Asch. The experiment was never about vision. The question was: **what does a person do when the whole group says the opposite of what they can see?**

WHY THIS MATTERS

The answer shocked everyone. Alone, participants almost never got it wrong — less than 1% of the time. In front of the group, they gave the group's wrong answer in about **36%** of trials, and **74%** gave in at least once (Asch, 1951).

But there was an even more important finding. When **a single actor** gave the right answer, almost everyone broke free: only 5% kept following the group.

That proves two things you'll use for the rest of this book. First: **a group changes what people say — and sometimes what they see.** Second: **one ally is enough to break the pressure.** Keep the second one in mind. It'll be decisive in Part IV.

THE INVISIBLE STRUCTURE

In any meeting, dinner or party there's a structure of power no one says out loud. Four roles show up almost every time:

— **The real Alpha** — not always the loudest. It's the person others look at after someone speaks. Comfortable with silence. When they talk, the room adjusts.

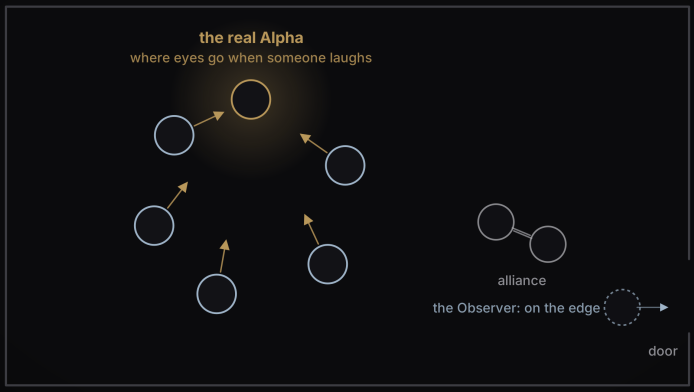
— **The Shadow** — influences without taking centre stage. Says little, but decisions go through them. Watch who the leader consults in private.

— **The Performer** — needs attention. Loud, tells stories, looks for reactions. Often the most insecure person in the room.

— **The Observer** — stays on the edge, says little, sees everything. Might be shy. Or might be the one who worked out first what's going on.

FIG. 05

Reading the room



When the group laughs, eyes go to whoever's in charge.

THE SIGNS IN 60 SECONDS

1. **Where eyes go** when someone makes a joke or a proposal. To whoever has real power.
2. **Who laughs at whose jokes.** Laughter flows up the hierarchy — and says more than it seems. Christopher Oveis and colleagues recorded fraternity students, some high-status, some newcomers. High-status members laughed more **dominantly** — louder and more varied; newcomers more **submissively**. And listeners could guess status from the laugh alone (Oveis et al., 2016).
3. **Who interrupts whom** — and who never gets interrupted.
4. **Where people sit** — head of the table, centre, near the door.
5. **Who speaks first and who speaks last.** Often, the most powerful speaks at the end.
6. **Who moves freely** around the space and who asks permission.

ALLIANCES AND TENSIONS

— People who **laugh together and mirror each other** are aligned (remember the chameleon effect, Chapter 4).

— People who **avoid each other's eyes** have tension.

— If someone **changes posture when another person walks in**, there's history between them — a deviation from baseline with a topic: that person.

HOW TO POSITION YOURSELF

— **You don't need to be the Alpha.** You need to know who it is.

— **Talk to the Shadow before the meeting**, not during.

— **Don't feed the Performer** at others' expense.

— **Never underestimate the Observer.**

And remember Asch: if everyone in a room agrees with something that looks wrong to you, **find the one person who doesn't**. One ally is enough.

> *The most dangerous person in the room is the one you never thought to look at twice.*

You've finished Part I. You can now read masks, baselines, faces, bodies, words, messages and groups. In Part II you'll meet the people who use all of this against you — starting with an uncomfortable question: **why do they choose you?**

USE THIS

PROTECT YOURSELF	Before proposing something important to a group, identify the Alpha and the Shadow and talk to them first, in private. A proposal backed before the meeting is rarely shot down in it.
HELP SOMEONE	Notice who keeps getting interrupted or ignored. Give them the floor: "Hang on, Anna was saying something." It costs you one sentence — and, as Asch showed, one ally changes everything.

TODAY'S PRACTICE

At your next meeting or group dinner, don't take part for the first two minutes. Just watch. Identify the Alpha, the Shadow, the Performer and the Observer. Afterwards, check your read against how the decisions went.

EPISODE 7 · END OF MONTH

End-of-month meeting. Marta makes a joke about the client and the room laughs. Inês, still new, notices where people look when they laugh.

When it's time to choose who leads the new project, Marta says she'll decide tomorrow. On the way out, Inês sees her go into her office with Sofia and close the door.

That night, Rui is on the stairs changing a lightbulb. He hesitates, as if about to say something. “Sofia... does she come to the building often?” Inês says yes, sometimes. He nods and goes back to the bulb.

What didn't Rui say?

REVIEW · PART I

Before you move on to Part II, stop for a moment.

Of the people Inês has met, who do you trust most? And who do you trust least?

Now the hard question: what made you think that — something that person **said**, or something they **did, more than once?**

Write your answers on a sheet of paper and keep it. You'll need it at the end of the book.

PART II

The Predators

People who want to use you rarely look dangerous.
They look perfect.

CHAPTER

08

Why They Choose You

New York, 1981. Two researchers, Betty Grayson and Morris Stein, film 60 people walking down a Manhattan street in the middle of the morning. Ordinary people, on their way to work or the shops.

Then they show the videos to men convicted of violent crimes and ask a simple question: **who would you pick?**

The choices repeat. And they're not the smallest or most fragile people. They're the ones who **walk a certain way**: uneven steps, head down, eyes on the ground, movements that look disconnected from the body (Grayson & Stein, 1981). The prisoners couldn't explain why. They just knew.

Predators read people too. This chapter is about what they read in you.

WHY THIS MATTERS

Part I taught you to read others. But the most important read is the one you do on yourself — because the tactics you'll meet in the next chapters are built to fit your open doors.

And the people looking for those doors are good at it. In a study of 47 inmates at a maximum-security prison in Canada, those who scored highest on the **interpersonal and affective traits of psychopathy** — superficial charm, low empathy — were **more accurate** at guessing, from gait alone, who had been a victim before. And they were the ones most likely to say they'd looked at the walk (Wheeler, Book & Costello, 2009).

In other words: reading yourself isn't a self-help exercise. It's defence. If you don't know where you're vulnerable, someone will find out before you do.

WHAT THEY LOOK FOR

They don't look for weakness. They look for **usefulness and access**:

- **High empathy** — you feel other people's pain as your own. The manipulator turns it into obligation (remember the Victim Mask in Chapter 1).
- **Moments of transition** — the end of a relationship, a move to a new city, grief, losing a job. You're more open, with less of a net around you.
- **Loneliness** — people with few people around them have few people to warn them. Remember Asch (Chapter 7): one ally is enough to break the pressure. With no allies, no one breaks it.
- **Need for approval** — trouble saying "no", fear of letting people down.
- **Too much responsibility** — you feel you have to fix everyone's problems.
- **Optimism about people** — "everyone has a good side".

Notice something: almost all of these are **qualities**. That's exactly why they get exploited.

> *They don't choose you because you're weak. They choose you because you're useful — and available.*

IT'S NOT YOUR FAULT

Responsibility for manipulation always belongs to the manipulator. Full stop.

The 60 pedestrians in New York did nothing wrong. They were just walking. Knowing your open doors isn't accepting blame — it's gaining the ability to close them when you need to.

HOW TO READ YOURSELF

Answer honestly:

1. What stage of life am I in right now? Stable, or in transition?
2. If something goes wrong, who do I tell?
3. Who do I find it hardest to say "no" to?
4. Which compliment disarms me fastest?
5. When did I last feel I had to "earn" someone's affection?

The answers show you where someone would get in. In the next seven chapters you'll see exactly *how* — starting with the kind of person who does this on purpose.

USE THIS

PROTECT YOURSELF	In times of transition — a break-up, a move, a loss — slow everything down. No big decisions, no new relationships at high speed. That's when you're easiest to read.
HELP SOMEONE	If someone close to you has just been through a break-up, a move or a loss, stay closer during that time. It's when they most need a net — and when predators show up most.

> *Close your doors before someone finds them.*

TODAY'S PRACTICE

Pick your two “open doors” from this chapter's list. Next to each one, write the name of someone you trust who you'll ask to warn you if anyone starts using them.

EPISODE 8 · PORTO

On a Sunday afternoon, Inês is on the phone with Carolina, her best friend back in Porto. She tells her everything: Daniel, work, the flat. “And have you got anyone there?” Carolina asks. “I've got Sofia. She's almost like you.”

Inês remembers that, in the very first week, Sofia asked about her ex. How long they'd been together, why it ended, whether he still called. Inês told her. At the time it felt good to have someone to tell.

At the end of the call, Carolina says: “I'll come down in November, OK? I want to meet all these people.”

If you were Carolina, what would you ask?

CHAPTER

09

The Dark Triad

Seattle, the 1970s. Ted Bundy is a law student, volunteers on a crisis hotline and is described by people who know him as charming, polite, helpful.

To get close to his victims, he often uses the same trick: an arm in a fake sling and a request for help carrying some books to his car. He doesn't start with force. He uses his victims' wish to **help**.

He was convicted of murdering several women and executed in 1989. Bundy is the extreme — and it's important to say so straight away: the vast majority of people with these traits never commit a crime. They use the same charm at the office, in the family and in love.

THREE TRAITS THAT TRAVEL TOGETHER

In 2002, psychologists Delroy Paulhus and Kevin Williams named a pattern that kept turning up in research: three different traits that overlap and often travel together — **narcissism, Machiavellianism and psychopathy**. They called it the **Dark Triad** (Paulhus & Williams, 2002).

The central point of the research is this: these are **traits that come in degrees**. Everyone has a little. What matters isn't whether someone "is" a narcissist — it's *how much*, and what it costs you.

WHY THIS MATTERS

It might sound like something from the movies. It isn't.

Paul Babiak, Craig Neumann and Robert Hare assessed 203 managers and executives from seven companies, all selected for leadership pro-

grammes. About **4%** reached the psychopathy threshold used in research — far above what's estimated for the general population. And the most revealing finding: these managers were rated as **more charismatic and better communicators**, but **worse at actual performance** — management, teamwork, results (Babiak, Neumann & Hare, 2010).

In other words: **charm is exactly what gets them promoted** — and performance is what gives them away. That's the gap from Chapter 1 in its purest form: the Competence Mask winning over people who don't look at results.

THE NARCISSIST

— **Needs constant admiration.**

— **Reacts badly to criticism** — with anger, coldness or revenge.

— **Sees people as mirrors** — they're worth something as long as they make him feel big.

How you spot him: conversations always come back to him. Your achievements get downplayed or absorbed (“that was thanks to me”). Your problems bore him.

THE MACHIAVELLIAN

— **Strategic and calculating.**

— **Sees relationships as a game** — who's useful, who isn't.

— **Patient** — can wait months to get what they want.

How you spot them: charming with whoever has power, cold with whoever doesn't. Collects information on everyone. Rarely reveals what they think. Remember the Shadow, in Chapter 7.

THE FUNCTIONAL PSYCHOPATH

— **Easy, superficial charm** — like Bundy.

— **Lies naturally**, without the stress signals you learned in Part I. That's why the baseline (Chapter 2) and patterns count for more than any in-the-moment signal.

— **Feels no remorse** — only the inconvenience of consequences.

How you spot them: their life story has lots of "enemies", "crazy" exes and burned bridges. Their apologies are words without change.

> *The most common sign in all three: the rules they demand of others don't apply to them.*

WHAT TO DO WITH THIS

Don't diagnose anyone. You don't need to know what someone "is" to see **what they're doing to you**. Notice patterns and protect yourself from them.

And notice what Bundy exploited: the wish to help — one of the open doors from Chapter 8. Charm finds the door; the pattern walks through it. In the next chapter you'll see the most common way it's done: **love that arrives too fast**.

USE THIS

PROTECT YOURSELF	Notice how the person talks about people who are no longer useful to them: exes, former partners, old friends. That's how, one day, they'll talk about you.
HELP SOMEONE	If someone describes a relationship with these patterns, don't say "he's a narcissist". Describe behaviours: "I've noticed conversations always come back to him." Labels make people defend him. Facts make them think.

TODAY'S PRACTICE

Think of the person who drained you most in the past. Reread this chapter's descriptions. Not to label them — to recognise the pattern next time, sooner.

EPISODE 9 · THE ONES BEFORE

Over coffee, Sofia tells Inês what the team was like before she arrived. Rita, who left in March, "was really jealous, poor thing". Joana, who asked for a transfer to Porto, "couldn't handle any pressure at all". Beatriz, who was there two years, "would do anything to make herself look good".

"It's different with you," she says. "You're one of the good ones."

The following week, Marta asks Sofia to present to the client the proposal Inês wrote. Sofia presents it very well.

How many people have left this team in the past year?

CHAPTER

10

Love Bombing: the Love That Traps You

He introduced himself as Simon Leviev, son of a diamond tycoon. His real name was Shimon Hayut. He met women on Tinder and, on the first date, flew them by private jet to another country.

Then came the messages at all hours. The good-morning voice notes. The fast declarations. The plans for the future — a house, travel, children.

Weeks later came the crisis: "my enemies are after me", blocked cards, an urgent request for money "just for a few days". According to the documentary *The Tinder Swindler* (Netflix, 2022), he took around $10 million from his victims.

The private jet wasn't the trick. The **speed** was.

WHAT IT IS

Love bombing is a flood of attention, affection and promises at the start of a relationship — romantic, a friendship or even professional. The goal isn't to love you. It's to create **emotional dependence fast**, before you've had time to see who the person is.

WHY THIS MATTERS

For a long time, "love bombing" was just an internet phrase. In 2017, Claire Strutzenberg and colleagues ran one of the first studies on it, with 484 young adults. Love bombing was linked to **more narcissism** and

lower self-esteem in the person doing it — and to more texting and social media in the relationship (Strutzenberg et al., 2017).

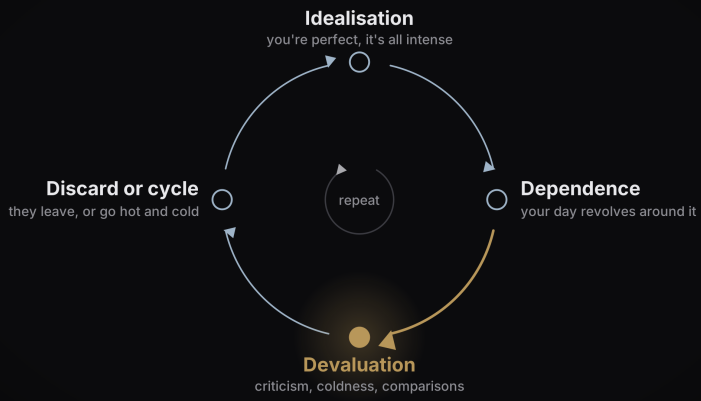
In other words: behind the excess of love there's often someone who needs to **control** — and who feels small inside. It's the narcissist from Chapter 9, with flowers in hand.

And that's exactly why it works: it uses what we want most — to be seen and loved — as bait. People who don't recognise it mistake the trap for the best moment of their life, and spend the following months trying to get back there.

THE STAGES

FIG. 06

The love bombing cycle



The cycle doesn't end. It speeds up.

1. **Idealisation** — you're perfect. No one understands you like he does. Everything is intense, fast, magical.
2. **Dependence** — you get used to that dose of attention. Your day starts revolving around it.

3. **Devaluation** — the attention starts slipping. Criticism, coldness, comparisons appear. And you work hard to get back to stage 1.
4. **Discard or cycle** — either they drop you, or they alternate hot and cold to keep you hooked. You'll see why this hooks so hard in Chapter 14.

THE SIGNS

- **Speed** — intimacy that should take months happens in days.
- **Disproportionate intensity** — expensive gifts, huge declarations, "soulmates" too early.
- **Fast-forwarded future** — moving in, trips, children, business partnerships, before there's any foundation.
- **Total attention** — constant messages, always available, wants to know everything.
- **Discomfort with your "no"** — when you slow down, they're hurt, they push, or they blame you.
- **Little real history** — you know a lot about what they feel for you and little about their life.

The last one is the most ignored — and the most important. In the *Tinder Swindler* cases, the victims knew everything about his feelings and almost nothing they could **verify**. It's the gap from Chapter 1: lots of declaration, little repeated behaviour.

REAL LOVE VS. LOVE BOMBING

Real love	Love bombing
Grows over time	Explodes at once
Respects your pace	Pushes your pace
Wants to know you	Wants to have you
Accepts a “no”	Punishes a “no”
Is consistent	Is intense, then unstable

> *People who like you have time. People who want to trap you are in a hurry.*

HOW TO PROTECT YOURSELF

— **You slow down.** If the other person won't accept your pace, you already have your answer.

— **Notice the discomfort with “no”.** It's the fastest test (remember boundaries, in Chapter 4).

— **Ask about the past.** How did their previous relationships end? How do they talk about their exes? (Chapter 9.)

— **Give it time.** Love bombing rarely survives a few months without showing stage 3.

Love bombing opens the door. The next step is locking you inside — away from the people who could warn you. That's Chapter 11.

USE THIS

PROTECT YOURSELF	The 90-day rule: no big decisions — money, moving in, cutting someone off — in the first three months. People who like you will wait.
HELP SOMEONE	If a friend is “on cloud nine” with someone they met weeks ago, don't attack that person. Ask: “And how does he react when you tell him no?” A question plants a doubt. An attack forces your friend to choose.

TODAY'S PRACTICE

Write down three paces you think are healthy at the start of a relationship — for example, “meeting his friends only after a month”. Next time someone tries to speed things up, you'll have a pattern to compare against.

EPISODE 10 · NOVEMBER

Daniel invites Inês to spend Christmas with his family in Viseu. She says it's early, that she doesn't feel ready yet. He's quiet for a few seconds. “You're right. Next year, then.” And he changes the subject to the film they want to see.

That week, Sofia turns up at Inês's desk with a box of pastéis de nata, because “you looked like you needed them”. On Wednesday, she gives her a notebook just like her own. On Friday, on the way out: “You're the only person here who gets me, you know? Really. I've never had a friend like you.”

Carolina postpones her visit to Lisbon until January. Inês doesn't even mind much. There's so much going on.

Who's in a hurry?

CHAPTER

11

Isolation: How They Pull You Away from the People Who Protect You

England, 14 August 2010. Sally Challen, 56, kills her husband, Richard, at home, with a hammer. She's convicted of murder the following year and sentenced to life.

The case looks simple. It wasn't.

Over decades of marriage, according to her sons and her lawyers, Richard controlled her: the money, the outings, the friendships. He humiliated her, cheated on her and stopped her going out with other people without him. Her friends gradually disappeared. In the end, she had almost no one.

In 2019, the Court of Appeal quashed the murder conviction. Sally Challen ended up convicted of manslaughter and walked free. The case became the first major court test of a new idea: **coercive control**.

WHY THIS MATTERS

Sociologist Evan Stark spent years studying cases like this and reached a conclusion that changed how abuse is seen: the most dangerous thing often isn't physical violence. It's **a pattern of control** that strips the victim, little by little, of freedom, resources and — above all — people (Stark, 2007). In England and Wales, coercive control has been a crime since 2015.

And isolation is the piece that makes all the others possible. Remember Asch, in Chapter 7: with one ally in the room, almost everyone resisted group pressure. **Isolation is the removal of that ally.** On your own, no one

tells you “this isn't normal” — and without that outside voice, you accept more and more.

In other words: when someone pulls you away from your people, they're not just taking your time. They're switching off your alarm.

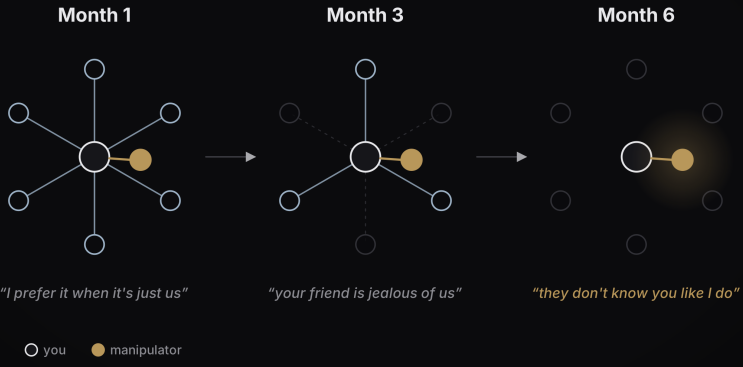
IT'S NEVER DIRECT

No one says “drop your friends”. It's done gradually, with apparent affection.

FIG. 07

Isolation

SOURCE: Evan Stark, coercive control (2007)



Nobody isolates you overnight. One tie is cut at a time.

The lines of isolation:

- **“Your friend is jealous of us.”**
- **“Your family never valued you the way I do.”**
- **“I prefer it when it's just the two of us.”**
- **“They don't know you like I do.”**
- **“I've noticed you're different after you see them.”**

Each line, on its own, seems harmless. Together, they build a wall — the gap (Chapter 1) that only shows in the pattern.

THE TACTICS

— **Creating conflict** — arguments every time you're about to see someone, so going out costs you.

— **Becoming the only option** — plans booked for the same days you'd already booked.

— **Poisoning the picture** — negative things about your friends, true or not.

— **Playing the victim** — "you're off with them and I'm stuck here alone".

— **Controlling resources** — money, car, phone, schedules. It's what Sally Challen's sons described.

— **Moving away** — "let's start over somewhere else".

HOW YOU KNOW IT'S HAPPENING

— **You see your friends less and less** and aren't sure why.

— **You've started hiding** things about the relationship from people who love you.

— **You feel you have to "defend"** the person all the time.

— **Your friends have stopped inviting you** because you always say no.

— **You feel relief when the person isn't there** — and guilt for feeling relief.

> *People who love you want you to have a full life. People who want to control you want to be your whole life.*

When there's no one outside left to confirm what you see, the last step is making you doubt what you see. That's Chapter 12.

USE THIS

PROTECT YOURSELF	Set a fixed date with your people — a dinner a month, a call a week — and don't negotiate it with anyone. It's your Asch ally, with a date in the diary.
HELP SOMEONE	If a friend has drifted away, don't stop inviting them just because they always say no. Keep going, without guilt or pressure: “That's fine. The invitation stands.” For someone being isolated, knowing the door is still open is everything.

TODAY'S PRACTICE

Write the names of the five people who mattered most to you two years ago. How many have you seen in the past month? If the list has shrunk and you don't know why, it's worth thinking about what changed.

EPISODE 11 · DECEMBER

Carolina calls on Sunday night. Inês sees the name on the screen and lets it ring — she's on the sofa with Sofia, who came over for dinner. “I'll call her back.”

Sofia asks about Carolina. Inês tells her she's postponed the visit again. “Sorry to say this,” says Sofia, “but long-distance friends are like that. Always busy for you. I'm here.”

Later, apropos of nothing: “Daniel's sweet, but I don't think he knows you the way I do.”

Inês doesn't call Carolina that night. Or the next.

Who is Inês further from today than in September?

CHAPTER

12

Gaslighting: When They Make You Doubt Your Own Memory

London, 1938. A play by Patrick Hamilton called Gas Light opens. Every night, a husband dims the gas lights in the house. When his wife notices the light fading, he assures her she's imagining things. He does the same with objects that go missing, with sounds in the attic, with everything she sees.

Little by little, she stops trusting her own mind.

In 1944, the film with Ingrid Bergman made the story famous. In 2022, *gaslighting* was Merriam-Webster's word of the year. Eighty years on, everyone knows the word. Almost no one recognises the thing while it's happening to them.

WHAT IT IS

Gaslighting is when someone **repeatedly denies your reality** until you start doubting your memory, your perception and your judgement.

“I never said that.” “You're exaggerating.” “That never happened.” “You're too sensitive.”

WHY THIS MATTERS

For years, gaslighting was talked about as if it were just a psychological problem between two people. Sociologist Paige Sweet showed it's more than that. She interviewed 43 women who had survived domestic violence and found that gaslighting works because **it leans on ideas society already holds** — such as that certain people are “too emotional” or “un-

stable" — and on institutions where the victim already has little credibility (Sweet, 2019).

In other words: whoever gaslights you doesn't need to convince you from scratch. They use doubts that already exist — and, after the isolation of Chapter 11, there's no one outside left to contradict them.

HOW IT WORKS

1. **Denial** — they deny what they said or did, even with proof.
2. **Minimising** — "it was just a joke", "it was nothing".
3. **Reversal** — the problem becomes your reaction, not what they did.
4. **Repetition** — so many times you stop trusting yourself.
5. **Dependence** — since you no longer trust your judgement, you start trusting theirs.

Notice step 3: it's the "attack the questioner" from Chapter 5, turned into a system.

THE SIGNS IN YOU

Gaslighting is spotted more by what it makes you feel than by what the person does:

— **You apologise constantly**, without quite knowing why.

— **You doubt your memory** in situations that used to be clear.

— **You feel like you're "going crazy".**

— **You've started saving messages** to prove to yourself what happened.

— **You make excuses** for the person's behaviour to others.

— **You no longer know what's you exaggerating** and what's real.

> *If you need proof to believe your own memory, the problem isn't your memory.*

HOW TO PROTECT YOURSELF

— **Write it down.** A simple, private record of what happens, with dates. Remember Chapter 6: what's written protects you. It's not for arguing — it's for you.

— **Don't argue about reality.** With someone who gaslights, debating "what happened" never ends. Say "I remember it differently" and close it.

— **Check outside.** Talk to someone you trust. It's Asch's ally again: an outside view gives you back your footing.

— **Look at the pattern, not the episode.** Anyone can misremember once. Denying your reality as a habit is something else.

Gaslighting makes you doubt yourself. The next tactic makes you doubt your place — by bringing a third person into the relationship. That's Chapter 13.

USE THIS

PROTECT YOURSELF	Keep a private, dated record in your phone's notes. Not to prove anything to anyone. To prove it to yourself.
HELP SOMEONE	When someone tells you something and adds "maybe I'm overreacting", validate before giving an opinion: "What you're describing makes sense." For someone living with gaslighting, hearing that gives them their memory back.

TODAY'S PRACTICE

Think of a recent situation where you left a conversation feeling you were wrong — without quite knowing why. Write down what happened, in order, as if telling a friend. Read on paper, how does it look?

EPISODE 12 · THE SLACK MESSAGE

At Tuesday's meeting, Marta asks why the client got the old version of the presentation. Inês remembers perfectly: on Friday, Sofia messaged her on Slack, “send v2, v3 isn't approved yet”.

After the meeting, she tells her so. Sofia frowns. “Me? I never said that. Inês, you've been so tired... It's not the first time you've got mixed up, is it? I just want to help you.”

That night, Inês opens Slack to check. The message is there. She stares at it for a long time, not quite knowing what to do with it.

What did Inês feel first: anger or doubt?

CHAPTER

13

Triangulation and Provoked Jealousy

London, November 1995. In a BBC interview watched by millions, Princess Diana talks about her marriage to Prince Charles and says a line that went down in history: "There were three of us in this marriage, so it was a bit crowded."

Whose fault it was doesn't matter here. What matters is the shape: a relationship of two that comes to be lived as three — with someone always present, even when they're not in the room.

When that third person is brought in **on purpose**, to create insecurity and control, it's called **triangulation**.

WHY THIS MATTERS

Psychiatrist Murray Bowen spent decades studying whole families and reached a conclusion that applies to almost every relationship: when tension between two people rises, one of them tends to **pull in a third** to relieve the pressure — a child, a friend, an ex, a colleague (Bowen, 1978). Triangles are the smallest stable unit of a relationship system.

Often it happens without intent. But manipulators use it **on purpose** — and the effect is always the same: instead of looking at what's going on between the two of you, you start looking at the third person.

In other words: while you're comparing yourself, you don't notice what's being done to you.

HOW IT SHOWS UP

— **Constantly talking about an ex**, in an ambiguous way.

— **Praising someone else in front of you** — “She's so calm, nothing ever bothers her.”

— **Answering other people's messages** while ignoring yours (remember Chapter 6).

— **Mentioning that “someone” is interested.**

— **At work** — “your colleague did this in half the time”.

— **In the family** — comparing siblings.

THE GOAL

1. **Getting you to compete** — you start working to be “better” than the third person.
2. **Shifting the focus** — instead of looking at their behaviour, you look at the threat.
3. **Gaining power** — whoever provokes jealousy controls the relationship.
4. **Making you look unstable** — if you react, you're “jealous” and “possessive”. And here triangulation joins up with the gaslighting of Chapter 12.

THE SIGNS

— **You feel jealousy** in a relationship where you didn't before — a deviation from *your* baseline (Chapter 2).

— **The third person comes up in conversation** strangely often.

— **When you complain**, the answer is “you're imagining things”.

— **You feel you're always being compared.**

> *People who value you don't enter you in a contest.*

HOW TO PROTECT YOURSELF

— **Name the pattern calmly, once** — "I notice you talk about her a lot when we've fallen out. Why?"

— **Don't compete.** The moment you play the game, you've lost.

— **Notice whether the behaviour stops** when you point it out. If it carries on or gets worse, it wasn't an accident.

Triangulation messes with your place. But there's an even stronger tactic — one that messes with your brain chemistry and explains why so many people can't leave. That's Chapter 14.

USE THIS

PROTECT YOURSELF	When you feel a new jealousy in an old relationship, ask yourself: "Did this start in me, or with something this person does?"
HELP SOMEONE	In the family or at work, refuse to be the third corner. When someone badmouths another person to get you on their side, reply: "That's something you need to talk to her about."

TODAY'S PRACTICE

Think of a relationship — personal or professional — where you feel constantly compared. Who brings in the comparison? Is it always the same person?

EPISODE 13 · THE NEW GIRL

In January, a new designer joins the team, Leonor. At lunch, Sofia sits next to her and spends the hour laughing at her jokes. “Leonor's so easy-going, isn't she? Never complains about anything.” She looks at Inês. “It's good to be around people like that.”

At the weekend, Daniel tells Inês, a bit embarrassed, that Sofia messaged him on Instagram. “She said you've been really stressed and that I should be patient with you. It was nice, I suppose. But it felt strange.”

How many people are in this relationship?

CHAPTER

14

Silence and Intermittent Reinforcement: Why You Can't Leave

Harvard University, the 1950s. Psychologist B. F. Skinner trains pigeons to peck a button for food.

When the food comes **every time**, the pigeons peck as much as they need to — and if the food stops, they give up quickly.

When the food comes **unpredictably** — sometimes on the first peck, sometimes on the twentieth — something else happens. The pigeons peck non-stop. And they keep pecking long after the food has stopped coming (Ferster & Skinner, 1957).

It's the same mechanism as slot machines. And certain relationships.

WHY THIS MATTERS

The question that causes most shame for people in a relationship that's hurting them is: *"Why don't you just leave?"*

In 1981, psychologists Donald Dutton and Susan Painter gave an answer that took the blame off victims. They called it **traumatic bonding**: a bond that forms — and grows stronger — when there's an **imbalance of power** and when good and bad treatment **alternate** (Dutton & Painter, 1981). It isn't weakness. It's conditioning — the same thing that kept the pigeons on the button.

In other words: the good moments don't make up for the bad ones. **They're what hooks you.**

THE SILENT TREATMENT

Stopping talking to you as punishment. Ignoring messages, answering in single words, acting as if you don't exist — for hours or days — until you give in.

Don't confuse it with needing space:

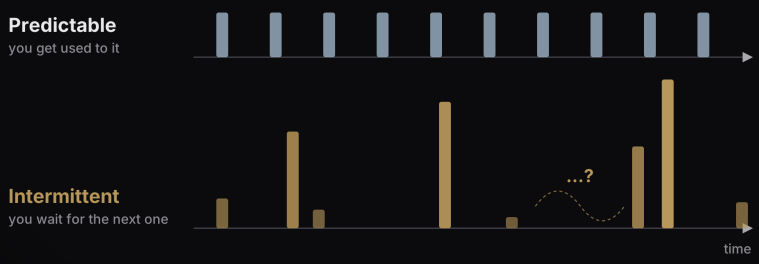
Healthy space	Silent treatment
“I need to think, let's talk tomorrow.”	Silence with no explanation.
Has a clear end.	Lasts until you give in.
Is for calming down.	Is for punishing.

Notice what silence does: it suddenly takes the reward away. Then, when it comes back, the reward tastes twice as good — it's the pigeon's button again.

FIG. 08

Intermittent reinforcement

SOURCE: B. F. Skinner, schedules of reinforcement (1957)



Unpredictable affection hooks harder than constant affection.

WHY IT HOOKS YOU

— **The good moments feel even better** after the bad ones.

— **You start working to "earn"** the good version.

— **You blame yourself for the bad moments** — "if I were different..."

— **You remember the peaks** more than the average.

> *You're not hooked on the person. You're hooked on the hope of getting back to the beginning.*

THE SIGNS

— **The relationship feels like a rollercoaster.**

— **You spend more time analysing** the person's behaviour than living the relationship.

— **Your mood depends on theirs.**

— **You're "addicted" to the make-ups.**

HOW TO PROTECT YOURSELF

— **Judge the average, not the peaks.** What's the relationship like on an ordinary day?

— **Write down the cycles** — when it was good, when it was bad, what changed. It's the record from Chapter 12 with a different purpose: seeing the pattern.

— **Don't reward silence.** Don't chase someone who punishes you with absence. Keep your life going.

And when you finally step away, the cycle has one last card to play. The food drops again, suddenly, after weeks of nothing. That's Chapter 15.

USE THIS

PROTECT YOURSELF	Judge the relationship by its average, not its best day. If the average is bad, the peaks are the hook.
HELP SOMEONE	Never tell someone caught in this cycle “just leave”. Say: “It makes sense that it's hard. This was built to hook you.” Taking away the shame is the first step to them being able to leave.

TODAY'S PRACTICE

On a scale of 1 to 10, score each day of the past week in a relationship that worries you. Work out the average. That's the number that describes the relationship — not the best day.

EPISODE 14 · FEBRUARY

On Monday and Tuesday, Sofia doesn't speak to Inês. She doesn't answer on Slack. At lunch, she sits with Leonor. Inês spends the evening trying to work out what she did.

On Wednesday morning, there's a coffee on Inês's desk, with a sticky note: "Missed you 💛". Sofia hugs her. They have lunch together. They laugh like they did in the first month.

The next week, it happens again: two days of silence, one day of hugs.

Inês texts Carolina at midnight: "I think it's my fault. Sometimes I say things without thinking."

How many good days did Inês have this month?

CHAPTER

15

Hoovering: the Comeback

You left. Or they did. Weeks have passed. And suddenly:

"I've been thinking about you a lot." "I've changed. I've been in therapy." "I found a photo of us." "I just wanted to know if you're OK."

The name comes from Hoover vacuum cleaners: **hoovering** is the attempt to "suck" you back into the relationship. And it's far more common than it looks.

When researcher René Dailey and colleagues studied on-again/off-again relationships, they found that **almost two in three** participants had been in a relationship that ended and started again. And those relationships, compared with stable ones, had **more uncertainty and more negative features** (Dailey et al., 2009).

Not every comeback is manipulation. But the comeback is the moment when a bad pattern has its best chance of starting over.

WHY THIS MATTERS

Remember Skinner's pigeons, in Chapter 14: what kept them pecking wasn't the food — it was the **possibility** of it coming back. Hoovering is exactly that: after weeks of nothing, the reward drops again. And the brain, which had started to give up, lights back up.

In other words: the most dangerous moment often isn't the relationship. **It's the comeback.** It arrives when you're recovering, with the right words — and one "yes" throws away months of work.

WHY IT HAPPENS

It's not necessarily love. Often it's:

— **The new source of attention fell through.**

— **They need to confirm they still have power** over you.

— **They're bored** — remember the functional psychopath, in Chapter 9.

— **They need something** — money, a place to stay, contacts, ego.

THE FORMS

— **Nostalgia** — photos, songs, "remember when...".

— **Dramatic regret** — promises of change without actions.

— **Crisis** — illness, problems, "I've got no one else". It's the Victim Mask (Chapter 1).

— **Practical excuses** — "I left something of mine at your place".

— **Through others** — they reappear via your friends. It's triangulation (Chapter 13) in reverse.

— **Special dates** — birthdays and holidays are favourite moments.

REAL CHANGE OR HOOVERING?

— **Real change comes with actions over time**, not intense words.

— **Real change respects your "no" the first time.**

— **Real change takes concrete responsibility** — not "mistakes were made" (the distancing from Chapter 5), but "I did this".

— **Hoovering vanishes once it gets what it wants** — and the cycle starts over.

> *If the only thing that changed is the message, nothing changed.*

HOW TO PROTECT YOURSELF

— **Decide in advance.** Write down now, with a cool head, what you'll do if the person comes back. When it happens, follow what you wrote.

— **Don't reply in the moment.** Wait 24 hours before any reply.

— **Notice the timing.** Do they come back just when you're recovering? That's strategy.

— **Remember the average**, not the best days.

You've finished Part II. You now know the tactics. In Part III you'll see where they live day to day — at work, in the family, when you buy — starting with the six mental shortcuts everyone uses to persuade you.

USE THIS

PROTECT YOURSELF	Write your reply today for the day the person comes back, and save it on your phone. On that day, you don't think: you read.
HELP SOMEONE	If a friend is being "hoovered" back, remind them of their reasons, not yours: "Remember what you told me in March?" Their memory is worth more than your opinion.

TODAY'S PRACTICE

If someone has tried to come back more than once, write down the dates and the lines they used. You'll see the "changes" always follow the same script.

EPISODE 15 · THE APOLOGY

In March, Inês stops answering Sofia's late-night messages. She doesn't say anything, she just stops answering. For a week, Sofia is cold at the office.

On Friday, she turns up at Inês's flat unannounced, with flowers. Her eyes full of tears. “I'm sorry. I'm going through a horrible time at home and I took it out on you. You're the only person I've got.” She hugs her at the door.

Rui is leaving his flat at that moment. He sees the two of them, nods, and goes down the stairs slowly.

Have you seen this scene before in this book?

REVIEW · PART II

Go back to the sheet you wrote at the end of Part I.

Is the person you trusted least still the same? If you changed your mind, what made you change it — something that happened once, or something that kept happening?

And a new question: of the people in this story, who has already made Inês feel guilty when she'd done nothing?

Write it down, and keep the sheet again.

PART III

Power

Manipulation doesn't only happen in love. It happens at work, in families, in friendships — and in every purchase you make.

CHAPTER

16

The Six Triggers of Influence

New York, December 2008. Bernie Madoff, former chairman of the NASDAQ stock exchange, confesses to his sons that his investment fund is "one big lie". The next day he's arrested.

For decades, Madoff had promised what no one else did: steady returns, year after year, whether markets were up or down. And he didn't take just anyone. You had to be introduced. Some people waited months to get in. The most respected names were already there.

Reported losses reached around **$65 billion**. It was the largest Ponzi scheme in history. Madoff was sentenced to 150 years in prison.

The victims weren't fools: there were banks, foundations, professional investors. Madoff didn't fool them with a lie. He fooled them with **mental shortcuts** — several at once.

WHY THIS MATTERS

In 1984, psychologist Robert Cialdini published *Influence*, after years of studying — and working undercover in sales, fundraising and advertising — how people are led to say "yes". He concluded there are **six shortcuts** we use to decide quickly (Cialdini, 1984). They're useful: without them, we couldn't function. But whoever knows them can use them against you.

And they work even on intelligent people — especially on them, because they trust their own judgement. No one thinks they can be manipulated. That's exactly what makes you manipulable.

FIG. 09

SOURCE: Robert Cialdini, Influence (1984)

Cialdini's 6 triggers



If you feel rushed to decide, someone pulled a trigger.

1. RECIPROCITY

When someone gives us something, we feel obliged to give back.

— **Manipulative use:** an unrequested favour so they can later ask for something much bigger. A "gift" that leaves you in debt.

— **Defence:** thank the favour as a favour. "Thank you" doesn't mean "I owe you".

2. COMMITMENT AND CONSISTENCY

Once we've said "yes" to something small, we tend to say "yes" to the next thing, to look consistent.

Jonathan Freedman and Scott Fraser proved it in 1966. They asked homeowners to put a huge, ugly sign in their front garden saying "Drive Carefully". Only **17%** agreed. But in another group, weeks earlier, they'd

asked for something tiny — a small sticker about safe driving. In that group, **76%** later agreed to the huge sign (Freedman & Fraser, 1966).

— **Manipulative use:** something small, then something bigger, then something huge. “Since you helped with this, could you…”

— **Defence:** judge each request as if it were the first. You have the right to change your mind.

3. SOCIAL PROOF

We follow what others do, especially when uncertain. It's Asch from Chapter 7, outside the lab.

— **Manipulative use:** “everyone's already agreed”, “you're the only one who hasn't…”, fake reviews, queues created on purpose. In Madoff's case: “the best people are already in”.

— **Defence:** ask yourself “if nobody else were doing this, would I?”.

4. AUTHORITY

We obey people who seem to have status. In 1963, Stanley Milgram asked 40 men to give stronger and stronger electric shocks to another person, just because a man in a grey lab coat told them to continue. The shocks were fake — but they didn't know. **65%** went all the way to the maximum (Milgram, 1963).

— **Manipulative use:** fake experts, invented titles, a tone of absolute certainty. Madoff had chaired the NASDAQ. Holmes had former cabinet secretaries on her board (Chapter 1).

— **Defence:** check the authority. Confidence in the voice isn't competence.

5. LIKING

We say “yes” to people we like — and we like people who resemble us, flatter us and mirror us (the chameleon effect from Chapter 4).

— **Manipulative use:** strategic compliments, “we have so much in common”, calculated mirroring.

— **Defence:** separate the person from the proposal. “I like him” and “the proposal is good” are different decisions.

6. SCARCITY

We want more of what seems rare. In a classic study, the same cookies were rated more desirable when they were in a jar with **two** than in a jar with **ten** (Worchel, Lee & Adewole, 1975).

— **Manipulative use:** “today only”, “last few left”, “you have to decide now”. In Madoff's case: “not everyone gets in”.

— **Defence:** artificial urgency is a warning sign. Good opportunities rarely vanish in ten minutes.

> *People with a good offer let you think. People with a bad offer need you not to.*

Notice how many triggers Madoff used at once: authority, scarcity, social proof, consistency. Almost every scam uses three or more. And the place these triggers hide best behind “professionalism” is work. That's Chapter 17.

USE THIS

PROTECT YOURSELF	Before any “yes” involving money or commitment, ask yourself: “Which trigger am I feeling right now?” Naming it takes away half its power.
HELP SOMEONE	When an older relative tells you about a “once-in-a-lifetime opportunity” or an urgent call from “the bank”, help them name the triggers: urgency, authority, scarcity. That's how almost every scam works.

TODAY'S PRACTICE

In the next ad you see, identify which triggers it uses. Most use two or three at once. Once you see them, they stop working as well on you.

EPISODE 16 · THE WEEKEND

On a Thursday afternoon, Sofia asks Inês a favour: to cover Sofia's client over the weekend, because "my mum isn't well". Inês had arranged to go to Porto to see Carolina.

"I know it's a pain," says Sofia. "But after everything I did for you when you started... And you need to tell me today, Marta wants to know by six."

Inês covers the client. She cancels Porto.

On Monday, on Sofia's Instagram, there are photos from Saturday at a rooftop bar in Santos.

How many triggers fit into three sentences?

CHAPTER

17

Manipulation at Work

San Francisco, September 2016. Wells Fargo, one of the biggest banks in the United States, agrees to pay $185 million in fines. For years, employees had opened more than two million bank accounts and cards that customers had probably never asked for. Around 5,300 people had been fired over it.

But the interesting question isn't why 5,300 people did something wrong. It's why so many ordinary people did it at the same time.

The answer, according to regulators, lay in aggressive sales targets and the incentive system — daily pressure, impossible goals and an environment where people who missed targets were afraid. No one told anyone to lie. The system did it for them.

WHY THIS MATTERS

Work is where manipulation is most **acceptable** — because it hides behind "professionalism", "targets" and "that's how it works".

And remember Babiak's study, in Chapter 9: the managers with the most psychopathic traits were rated **more charismatic** and **worse at actual performance**. In other words, at work the Competence Mask (Chapter 1) doesn't just exist — it often gets **promoted**. People who can't read this end up doing the work and losing the credit.

THE PROFILES

— **The credit thief** — in meetings says "we did it"; with the boss says "I did it".

— **The friendly saboteur** — smiles to your face, undermines you in conversations you're not in.

— **The permanent-urgency boss** — everything is for yesterday, so you never have time to think or negotiate. It's the scarcity trigger (Chapter 16) as a management style.

— **The favour colleague** — always helps you, then collects at the worst moments. Reciprocity (Chapter 16).

— **The information gatekeeper** — controls what you know, so you depend on them. It's the Shadow from Chapter 7.

THE TACTICS

— **Meetings with no record** — verbal agreements that later "nobody remembers".

— **Vague requests** — if the task isn't clear, it's always your fault.

— **Public praise, private criticism** — or the reverse, whichever suits.

— **Professional triangulation** — "your colleague thinks that..." (Chapter 13).

— **Isolation** — leaving you off the emails, meetings or lunches where decisions are made (Chapter 11).

HOW TO PROTECT YOURSELF

— **Put everything in writing.** After every important conversation, send a short email: "Just to confirm what we agreed: ...". Remember Hancock (Chapter 6): when there's a record, people lie less.

— **Make your work visible.** Regular, direct updates to whoever makes the decisions.

— **Ask for clarity.** "To make sure I get this right: what does success look like for this task, and by when?"

— **Build relationships in several directions.** Don't depend on one person for information or reputation.

— **Read the room** (Chapter 7). Knowing who the Shadow is in your company is worth more than a lot of competence.

> *At work, whoever controls the information controls the narrative. Make sure your version is in writing too.*

At work, you can change jobs. There's one place where leaving is much harder — because the manipulation comes from people we love, and we call it “normal”. That's Chapter 18.

USE THIS

PROTECT YOURSELF	At the end of each week, send whoever makes the decisions a three-line update: what you did, what's next, what you need.
HELP SOMEONE	When you see a colleague being erased in a meeting, give them credit in public: “That was Anna's idea.” It costs you little and shows the whole room you're paying attention.

TODAY'S PRACTICE

Think of the last important verbal agreement you made at work. Is there a written record? If not, send a confirmation email today.

EPISODE 17 · THE PRESENTATION

The client loves the new campaign. At the all-hands meeting, Sofia presents it: “It was a team effort, Inês and I spent weeks on this.”

Later, Inês walks past Marta's office door and hears Sofia's voice: “...but the core idea was mine, Inês helped a lot with the execution.”

Inês goes back to her desk. She opens her email. She looks for the message she sent Marta in October with the first version of the idea. She can't find it — it had gone through Sofia's phone, “so it gets there faster”.

Where is Inês's version?

CHAPTER

18

Manipulation in Family and Friendships

Los Angeles, June 2021. Britney Spears, one of the most famous singers in the world, speaks in court. For 13 years she has lived under a legal conservatorship controlled largely by her own father: her finances, her career and decisions about her personal life. She describes the situation as abusive and asks the judge to end it.

In November that year, the conservatorship ends.

You don't need to take sides to see the essential point: the control that's hardest to recognise — and to break — is the kind that comes **from family**, wrapped in "it's for your own good".

WHY THIS MATTERS

In families, manipulation looks like love because it comes from people we love. We grow up with it and call it "normal".

Remember Murray Bowen, in Chapter 13: triangles show up mostly in families, when tension between two people is diverted onto a third — often a child. And psychotherapist Susan Forward named what keeps these patterns alive: **fear, obligation and guilt** — the "fog" that emotional blackmail leaves us in, and that stops us seeing what's going on (Forward, 1997).

In other words: not seeing the pattern in your family isn't a lack of intelligence. It's fog. Seeing the pattern doesn't force you to cut anyone off. It gives you **the choice** of how you relate.

IN THE FAMILY

— **Guilt as a tool** — "after everything I've done for you". It's reciprocity (Chapter 16) collected forever.

— **Fixed roles** — the "responsible one", the "problem one", the "favourite". Changing roles is seen as betrayal.

— **Conditional love** — affection when you obey, coldness when you don't. It's the intermittent reinforcement from Chapter 14.

— **Secrets and alliances** — one relative tells you things about another to get you on their side. Triangulation (Chapter 13).

— **Boundary invasion** — turning up unannounced, deciding for you, having an opinion on everything.

IN FRIENDSHIPS

— **The friend who only shows up when they need something.**

— **The friend who competes** — your good news is always topped by theirs.

— **The friend of disguised criticism** — "I'm just being honest".

— **The friend who spreads things** — tells you other people's secrets. They tell yours too.

— **The friend who can't handle your growth** — goes distant when things go well for you.

THE ENERGY TEST

There's a simple test that works better than any analysis: after you've been with someone, **how do you feel?** Light, motivated, understood? Or tired, small, anxious?

Once is a bad day. Always is a pattern — and you've known since Chapter 1 what a pattern means.

> *The right people don't make you feel you have to earn the place beside them.*

HOW TO PROTECT YOURSELF

— **Clear, calm boundaries** — "Thanks for your opinion, but this decision is mine."

— **Don't over-explain.** The more you justify a boundary, the more room you give for negotiating it.

— **Accept that some people won't change.** You can love someone and keep your distance.

— **Choose the dose.** With difficult relatives, it's not just "cut off" or "put up with it". It can be seeing them less often, for less time, in neutral places.

If the energy test is the best detector of bad relationships, there's an equally good detector for the good ones: how real interest behaves when no one's watching. That's Chapter 19.

USE THIS

PROTECT YOURSELF	Before a difficult family lunch, decide how long you'll stay and what your exit line is. Going with a plan is different from going and waiting.
HELP SOMEONE	If you're the "favourite" or the "responsible one", use that position to protect whoever got the worse role: don't join in the comparisons, and tell them, in private, that you see what's going on.

TODAY'S PRACTICE

List the ten people you talk to most. Next to each one, write how you usually feel after being with them. You don't need to do anything with the list. Just look at it.

EPISODE 18 · THE NEWS

Inês gets some good news: a piece she wrote has been picked for an advertising magazine. She tells Sofia first.

"Great!" says Sofia. "I was invited to write for them too, last year, but I said no — didn't have time for that sort of thing." She changes the subject to her weekend.

That night, Inês tells Daniel. He asks to read the piece, asks two questions about it and texts her at midnight: "Still thinking about your last line."

The next day, Inês wakes up tired without knowing why. She does the maths: she comes out of almost every lunch with Sofia tired.

After which of the two conversations did Inês feel bigger?

CHAPTER

19

Signs of Real and Fake Interest

Seattle, back in John Gottman's "Love Lab" (Chapter 3). This time, the team isn't looking for contempt. It's looking for something much smaller.

One partner says, looking out of the window: *"Look, a pretty bird."* It isn't a conversation about birds. It's a request — an **invitation** for the other's attention. Gottman called these small moments **bids**: attempts to connect.

And the other's response can go three ways: turning **towards** ("where?"), turning **against** ("I'm reading") or simply **ignoring** it.

Six years later, the couples who were still married had turned towards about **86%** of the time. Those who had divorced, about **33%** (according to data from Gottman's newlywed study).

It wasn't the grand declarations that separated the couples. It was the birds.

WHY THIS MATTERS

Wanting to know whether someone is interested is one of the oldest questions in the world — and the answer is almost never in what they say. Gottman's study shows why: **real interest lives in small, repeated responses**, not intense moments.

And this connects to everything you saw in Part II. Love bombing (Chapter 10) is made of huge moments. Intermittent reinforcement (Chapter 14) is made of peaks. Real interest is made of 86% "where?".

In other words: **if you only recognise fire, you'll always choose the person who burns you.**

SIGNS OF GENUINE INTEREST (TOGETHER, NOT ALONE)

— **Attention to detail** — remembers what you said days ago.

— **Body orientation** — feet and torso turned towards you (Chapter 4).

— **Initiative** — seeks you out without needing an excuse.

— **Time** — stays longer than they needed to.

— **Questions** — wants to know about you, not just talk about themselves.

— **Consistency** — the interest holds by day and by night, in public and in private.

— **Natural mirroring** — copies your posture with a delay, without realising (the chameleon effect from Chapter 4).

SIGNS OF FAKE OR STRATEGIC INTEREST

— **Interest that only shows up when they need something.**

— **Full attention in private, distance in public.**

— **Lots of praise, little curiosity** — says you're amazing, but knows nothing about you.

— **Intensity without consistency** — days of full attention followed by silence.

— **Available only at certain hours** — usually late at night (Chapter 6).

— **Promises without dates** — “we have to go...”, “one day we'll...”.

THE RIGHT QUESTION

Don't ask “does this person like me?”. Ask: **“does this person treat me consistently — when no one's watching, even when they don't need anything?”**

> *Real interest is boring in its consistency. Fake interest is exciting in its unpredictability.*

Consistency is the best sign that someone is with you. So when someone's consistency suddenly changes, it's the first sign they may be leaving. That's Chapter 20.

USE THIS

PROTECT YOURSELF	For a month, judge only by repeated actions. Don't answer words with devotion — answer actions in proportion.
HELP SOMEONE	When a friend asks “do you think he likes me?”, don't give an opinion. Ask: “What does he do, repeatedly?” The right question helps more than your answer.

TODAY'S PRACTICE

Think of someone you're interested in. Ignore what they say. List only what they do, repeatedly. The list answers the question.

EPISODE 19 · TUESDAY NIGHT

It's an ordinary Tuesday. Inês sends Daniel a photo of a cat on the wall opposite the office. He replies twenty minutes later, as always: “Looks like Tobias!” — the cat he had as a kid, which he told her about on their second date, in September.

At the same time, Sofia doesn't answer a work question from Inês. The next day, she turns up with two coffees and a box of chocolates: “Sorry about yesterday, darling. You know you're my person.”

Inês notices she never knows which Sofia she'll find in the morning.

Who remembered September?

CHAPTER

20

The Signs That Announce Betrayal

Virginia, February 2001. FBI agent Robert Hanssen is arrested in a park, after leaving secret documents hidden under a wooden footbridge. For about 22 years, on and off, he had sold secrets to the Soviet Union and then Russia. He received more than $1.4 million in cash and diamonds. He was sentenced to life in prison.

The most striking thing isn't what he did. It's **how many times the signs appeared** — and were explained away.

In 1990, his sister-in-law found a pile of cash in the house, and his brother-in-law, also FBI, recommended an investigation. Nothing happened. In 1993, Hanssen hacked into a colleague's computer and printed a classified document; he explained he was just demonstrating security flaws, and they accepted it. Later, he was caught installing a password-cracking program on his own computer; he got only a warning. In his final years, he repeatedly searched for his own name in FBI files.

Each sign, on its own, had an explanation. Together, they told a story no one read.

WHY THIS MATTERS

Betrayal is rarely a bolt from a clear blue sky. There are almost always clouds first — it's just that, up close, we don't want to see them.

And the Hanssen case shows why: it isn't a lack of signs. It's that each sign gets judged **on its own**, and each one has a reasonable explanation. It's exactly the mistake this book has taught you to avoid since Chapter 1:

a moment says nothing; a pattern says almost everything. And since Chapter 2: what counts is the **change from baseline**.

Betrayal, here, is any serious breach of trust: infidelity, a business partner who stabs you in the back, a friend who sells your secrets, a colleague who sabotages you.

THE FIVE SIGNS

1. **Routine changes with no explanation** — new hours, new habits, new "meetings". Change happens; the sign is the **lack of a natural explanation**, or an explanation that keeps changing.
2. **Sudden protection of privacy** — the phone now lies face down, new passwords, leaving the room to take calls. Everyone has privacy; the sign is the **sudden change** (Chapter 2).
3. **Emotional distance and irritation** — less curiosity about you, more impatience, new criticisms. Sometimes the person betraying needs to see you as "the problem" to justify what they're doing.
4. **Overcompensation** — unexpected gifts, sudden attention, unusual niceness. Guilt sometimes shows up as generosity.
5. **Stories that don't fit** — details that change when the story is told again, long answers to simple questions (Chapter 5), aggressive defensiveness at neutral questions.

AT WORK AND IN FRIENDSHIPS

— **A business partner who stops sharing numbers** or starts talking directly to your clients.

— **A friend who knows things** you only told one person.

— **A colleague who starts having meetings with your boss without you.**

— **Someone who stops telling you plans** they used to share.

> *One sign is coincidence. Several signs at once, starting at the same time, are a story.*

WHAT TO DO

— **Don't accuse based on one sign.** You could be wrong — and an unfair accusation destroys trust too (the Othello error, Chapter 2).

— **Watch the pattern for a while.** Write down what you see, with dates.

— **Ask open, calm questions** — "I've noticed you've seemed different. Is everything OK?" The reaction tells you a lot.

— **Protect yourself in parallel.** Access to accounts, documents, sensitive information: review who has what.

You've finished Part III. You know how to see. In Part IV you'll learn to do something with what you see — starting with the exact lines to use when someone tries to manipulate you.

USE THIS

PROTECT YOURSELF	Every so often, review who has access to what: passwords, shared accounts, documents. Not out of suspicion. Out of hygiene.
HELP SOMEONE	If you suspect a friend is being deceived, don't give them the "news" based on a single sign. Share facts, once, carefully, and let them decide: "I saw this. I thought you should know."

TODAY'S PRACTICE

Think of an important relationship. What's its baseline — routines, sharing, privacy? Write it down. It isn't suspicion: it's having a reference point, so a real change doesn't slip past you.

EPISODE 20 · APRIL

In April, Sofia starts having closed-door meetings with Marta, two or three times a week. She stops copying Inês on client emails. When Inês asks, she says: “Boring budget stuff, I don't want to bore you with it.”

One Friday, Marta announces to the team: there's a coordinator position. “We've decided it'll be Sofia.”

On the way out, Sofia gives Inês a big hug. “This is yours too, you know? I couldn't have done it without you.”

When did this start?

REVIEW · PART III

Take out your sheet again.

If you had to explain to someone, with facts and not impressions, why you distrust the person you distrust — which three moments would you pick?

And now the opposite: who, in this story, has never asked Inês for anything?

Keep the sheet. Not long now.

PART IV

Defence

Seeing is half of it. The other half is knowing what to do when you see.

CHAPTER

21

Lines to Answer With: Scripts for Every Tactic

New York University and the University of Sheffield, 2006. Psychologists Peter Gollwitzer and Paschal Sheeran pull together 94 studies on a simple question: why do so many people know what they should do — and then, in the moment, don't do it?

The answer they found is almost embarrassingly simple. People who decided **in advance**, in the format *"if X happens, then I'll do Y"*, followed through far more often than people who only had the intention. The effect was medium to large — rare in psychology (Gollwitzer & Sheeran, 2006).

They called them **implementation intentions**. This chapter calls them something else: **scripts**.

WHY THIS MATTERS

When someone manipulates you, the goal is to knock you off balance. Under pressure, nobody thinks well — remember Vrij, in Chapter 1: with a busy mind, control fails. That applies to you too. Manipulators count on you hunting for the perfect answer and, while you hunt, giving in.

In other words: **the best answer isn't the cleverest one. It's the one you already had ready.** Notice the format of the study — *if... then...* — it's the same pattern as Mischel and Shoda (Chapter 1), now working for you. Instead of reading other people's patterns, you create your own.

Say the lines calmly, without raising your voice, and don't justify them.

AGAINST RUSHING (SCARCITY, URGENCY — CHAPTER 16)

— "I don't decide anything under pressure. I'll let you know tomorrow."

— "If it has to be now, then it's no."

AGAINST GUILT (CHAPTER 18)

— "I appreciate what you did. It doesn't change my answer."

— "I can care about you and still say no."

AGAINST GASLIGHTING (CHAPTER 12)

— "I remember it differently. We're not going to agree on this."

— "I don't need you to agree with my memory."

AGAINST DISGUISED CRITICISM

— "What do you mean?" — and wait. It forces the person to say directly what they implied.

— "Was that meant to be funny?"

AGAINST TRIANGULATION (CHAPTER 13)

— "I'm not going to compete with anyone. If you prefer someone else, say so."

AGAINST LOVE BOMBING (CHAPTER 10)

— "I'm enjoying getting to know you. I'd rather take it slowly."

— "It's early for that. Let's see how it goes."

AGAINST ISOLATION (CHAPTER 11)

— "My friends are important to me. That's not up for discussion."

AGAINST THE SILENT TREATMENT (CHAPTER 14)

— "Whenever you want to talk, I'm here." — and get on with your life.

AGAINST "YOU'RE OVERREACTING"

— "Maybe. Even so, that's how I feel, and I want to talk about it."

AGAINST THE TRAP FAVOUR AND THE INVASIVE QUESTION

— "Thanks, but I'd rather not."

— "I'd rather not talk about that." — no explanation.

> *A "no" doesn't need defending. The more you justify yourself, the more doors you open for negotiation.*

THE BROKEN RECORD

In the 1970s, psychologist Manuel J. Smith described a technique that's still one of the most effective against persistence: **repeating the same sentence, in the same tone, without adding arguments** (Smith, 1975).

"I understand. My answer is no." Three times, if needed.

It works because manipulation needs **material**: every justification you give is a new door to negotiate through. The broken record gives them nothing to hold on to.

Lines protect you in the moment. But there's something stronger than a good line: a line you decided on before anyone tried to cross it. That's Chapter 22.

USE THIS

PROTECT YOURSELF	Save the lines from this chapter's training in a phone note called “Lines”. Reread it before difficult conversations.
HELP SOMEONE	Rehearse these lines with a friend who's going through something difficult. Saying them out loud to someone you trust makes it easier to say them to the person who needs to hear them.

TODAY'S PRACTICE

Pick the three tactics used on you most. For each one, write a line in the format “if he says X, I say Y”. Say each one out loud five times. When you need it, it'll come out on its own.

EPISODE 21 · NO

In May, Sofia asks Inês to cover one of her clients over the weekend again. “You need to tell me by six.”

Inês breathes. “I won't be able to. I've got plans.”

“Plans? What plans? After I've helped you so much…”

“I understand. I won't be able to.”

“Seriously, Inês? Like that?”

“I understand. I won't be able to.”

Sofia turns her back without another word. Inês's hands shake under the desk for ten minutes. Then she texts Carolina: “Is Saturday still on?”

How much did three sentences cost Inês?

CHAPTER

22

Boundaries That Aren't Up for Negotiation

Tokyo, 27 July 2021. The women's gymnastics team final at the Olympic Games. Simone Biles, 24, Olympic champion, the most famous gymnast in the world, does one vault — and leaves the arena with the team doctor.

When she comes back, she doesn't compete again. "I have to focus on my mental health," she tells reporters. "There's more to life than just gymnastics."

Millions watching, a team depending on her, a country waiting for gold. And she said no.

A week later, she came back for one event and won bronze on the beam. But what stayed from those Games wasn't the medal. It was the boundary.

WHAT A BOUNDARY IS

A boundary isn't a request. It's a decision about **what you do** when someone crosses a line.

"Don't shout at me" is a request. *"If you shout, I'll leave the conversation"* is a boundary.

Biles didn't ask anyone to stop pressuring her. She decided what she herself was going to do.

WHY THIS MATTERS

A boundary you don't keep teaches the other person exactly how far they can go. Remember Chapter 4: people who test small boundaries early tend to test big ones later. And without boundaries, everything you've learned so far isn't worth much: **you see everything — and accept everything**.

There's another reason. Anthropologist Robin Dunbar showed that our relationships are organised in **layers**: a very small core of very close people (around 5), then about 15, then about 50, up to roughly 150 stable relationships (Dunbar, 2010). There isn't room for everyone at the centre.

In other words: **trust is limited by nature**. Deciding who goes in each layer isn't coldness. It's managing a resource that isn't enough for everyone.

YOUR CORE BOUNDARIES

Define them before you need them:

- **Respect** — I don't accept insults, shouting or humiliation, not even as a joke.
- **Privacy** — my phone, my accounts and my conversations are mine.
- **Time** — I'm not available 24 hours a day. I reply when I can (Chapter 6).
- **Money** — I don't lend or invest under pressure (Chapter 16).
- **Relationships** — no one decides who I talk to (Chapter 11).
- **Body** — my “no” is final.

HOW TO COMMUNICATE A BOUNDARY

1. **Short** — one sentence.
2. **Calm** — no anger, no apologising.

3. **With a consequence** — what *you* will do, not what the other person has to do.
4. **Kept** — if you don't keep it, you've taught them your boundary is negotiable.

Example: *"When you raise your voice, I end the conversation. We'll pick it up when we're both calm."* And if the voice rises, you end it.

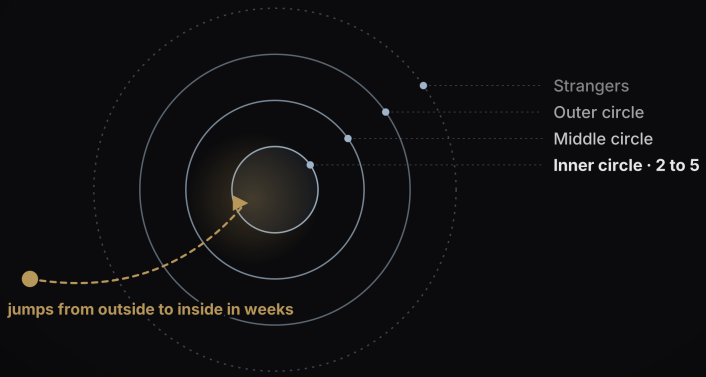
HOW PEOPLE REACT

- **Healthy people** — may be surprised, but adjust.
- **Manipulative people** — test the boundary. Once, twice, three times. They take offence. They play the victim (the Victim Mask, Chapter 1). They say you've changed.

> *Someone's reaction to your boundary tells you everything you need to know about them.*

FIG. 10

Circles of trust



Access is earned with time and proof, not intensity.

— **Inner circle** — 2 to 5 people who have proved their loyalty in hard times. They know almost everything.

— **Middle circle** — trusted friends and colleagues. They know enough.

— **Outer circle** — acquaintances. They know the basics.

No one jumps from outside to inside in a few weeks. Access is earned with **time and proof**, not intensity — and jumping circles fast is exactly what the Loyalty Mask (Chapter 1) and love bombing (Chapter 10) do.

A boundary protects you inside a relationship. Sometimes it isn't enough — and the only boundary left is leaving. That's Chapter 23.

USE THIS

PROTECT YOURSELF	Start with small boundaries. Keeping a small one (“if you're half an hour late, I'm leaving”) trains you to keep the big ones.
HELP SOMEONE	When someone close to you sets a boundary — even with you — respect it the first time and say: “Understood.” You're showing them what a healthy reaction looks like. Many people have never seen one.

TODAY'S PRACTICE

Write down three of your boundaries, each as one sentence with a consequence. Then write who is in each circle today. Is anyone in a circle they haven't earned yet?

EPISODE 22 · THE REACTION

On Monday, Sofia doesn't speak to Inês. On Tuesday, she sends her a long message at 00:30: that she always defended her, that everyone at the agency thought Inês was "arrogant" and only she protected her, that she never thought Inês was "that kind of person". On Wednesday, she cries in the kitchen in front of Leonor and Marta.

On Thursday, Leonor comes over to Inês and says quietly: "She did the same to me in my first week. To me and to Rita."

Inês doesn't reply to the 00:30 message. For the first time, she makes a list of the people she trusts. It's short. Sofia isn't on it.

What has Leonor just done for Inês?

CHAPTER

23

How to Leave and Not Go Back

Dallas, 3 July 1976. Tina Turner walks out of a downtown hotel, runs across a motorway and goes into another hotel on the other side. She has 36 cents in her pocket and a fuel card. She's injured. The manager recognises her and hides her for three days.

She was already a global star. But she had spent years in a violent, controlling marriage — and, like so many people, she hadn't left the first time, or the second.

That night she left. And she didn't go back. Years later, she would have the biggest phase of her career — under her own name.

WHY THIS MATTERS

Leaving a manipulative relationship — romantic, professional or a friendship — is harder than it looks from outside. Not because the person is weak, but because **the cycle was built to hold you**: it's Dutton and Painter's traumatic bonding (Chapter 14), made of an imbalance of power and good days among the bad.

And the moment of leaving is when the cycle fights hardest. That's why many people who leave without a plan go back — and every attempt, even a failed one, counts. Notice what Tina Turner did that night: she didn't argue, didn't negotiate, didn't explain. **She left, and went somewhere safe.**

In other words: leaving isn't a conversation. It's a plan.

BEFORE YOU LEAVE

— **Decide quietly.** Don't announce your intention before you're ready. Many manipulative people tighten control when they feel they're losing you.

— **Sort out the essentials.** Documents, money, access to your accounts, changed passwords, somewhere to go.

— **Tell your inner circle** (Chapter 22). Two people who know what's going on. It's Asch's ally (Chapter 7), for the hardest decision.

— **Write down your reasons.** A short, honest list. You'll need it on the days you miss them.

WHEN YOU LEAVE

— **Short and clear.** "This relationship is over." You don't need to convince anyone or win the final argument.

— **Don't negotiate.** Promises to change at this moment are part of the cycle.

— **Somewhere safe**, if there's any risk at all. Your safety comes first.

AFTER YOU LEAVE

— **No contact, wherever possible.** Block, mute, unfollow. Every message you read reopens the wound — it's intermittent reward again (Chapter 14).

— **Minimal contact, where it's unavoidable** (children, work): practical matters only, in writing, brief, without emotion.

— **Expect the hoovering** (Chapter 15). When it comes, you're not surprised — you're prepared.

— **Reread your list** when the nostalgia hits.

— **Rebuild your life** with people, routines and goals that are your own.

> *Leaving hurts for a while. Staying hurts for years.*

AN IMPORTANT NOTE

If you're in a situation involving violence, threats or danger, get specialist help. Most countries have a free, confidential domestic abuse or victim support helpline — search for the one where you live and save the number. In immediate danger, call your local emergency number (**911** in the US, **112** in Europe, **999** in the UK). You're not alone, and you don't have to sort this out without help.

Leaving is the decision of the person inside. But people inside rarely leave alone — they leave because someone outside never stopped being there. That someone could be you. That's Chapter 24.

USE THIS

PROTECT YOURSELF	Don't announce anything before you have the essentials in place. The plan is your protection.
HELP SOMEONE	If someone close to you has gone back to the relationship, never say "I told you so". Say: "I'm here whenever you need me." People who go back and feel ashamed stop telling you. People who feel the door is open leave again.

TODAY'S PRACTICE

Even if you're not in a relationship like this, do the exercise: who are the two people you'd call if you needed to get out of a difficult situation? If you don't have an answer, building that circle is your priority.

EPISODE 23 · JUNE

Inês asks Marta to move teams. She doesn't give long explanations: “I think I'll work better on Leonor's client.” Marta agrees.

For two weeks, Sofia sends messages. First affectionate, then hurt, then a photo of the two of them from the first month, captioned “remember us?”. Inês doesn't reply. She mutes the chat.

One Saturday, Carolina finally comes down to Lisbon. The two of them have dinner with Daniel on a terrace in Arroios. Halfway through dinner, Carolina says: “You know that on the phone, these past months, you sounded like a different person?”

When did Inês stop sounding like herself?

CHAPTER

24

How to Help Someone Who's Trapped

New York University, 1968. A student sits alone in a room, talking over an intercom with other participants, each in their own room. Suddenly, one of them starts having what sounds like an epileptic seizure. He asks for help, his voice failing.

What researchers John Darley and Bibb Latané wanted to know was simple: **who leaves the room to help?**

When the student thought he was the only one listening, **85%** went to help. When he thought four other people were listening, only **31%** did (Darley & Latané, 1968).

It wasn't a lack of compassion. It was the feeling that **someone else would deal with it**. They called it **diffusion of responsibility**.

WHY THIS MATTERS

When a friend is trapped in a relationship that's destroying them, there are almost always several people who notice. And almost always each one thinks someone else will do something.

And remember Asch (Chapter 7): when there was a single ally in the room, almost everyone broke free of group pressure. Put the two studies together and you have the central idea of this chapter: **people who are trapped rarely get out alone. They get out because someone outside decided to be the ally — instead of waiting for someone else to be.**

Everything you've read so far is for protecting yourself. This chapter is for protecting the people you love.

WHAT DOESN'T WORK

- **Attacking the person** — it forces your friend to defend them. It's the isolation of Chapter 11 working in the manipulator's favour.
- **Ultimatums** — "it's them or me" pushes them further in.
- **Labels** — "narcissist", "psychopath" sound like exaggeration and shut the conversation down (Chapter 9).
- **Rushing** — the decision to leave has to be theirs, in their own time.

WHAT WORKS

1. **Stay.** Your presence is exactly what isolation wants to destroy. Keep in touch, even if it's one message a week.
2. **Ask, don't tell.** "How do you feel after you've been together?" "What happens when you tell them no?" Questions let them reach the conclusions themselves — and their own conclusions are the only ones that stick.
3. **Talk about behaviour, not character.** "I've noticed you don't come to dinners any more", instead of "he's pulling you away from us".
4. **Validate what they feel.** "It makes sense that you're confused." People living with gaslighting need someone to confirm their reality (Chapter 12).
5. **Remind them who they are.** Talk about the things they loved, the people they were close to. The manipulator rewrote their identity. You keep the original.
6. **Help with practical things when they ask.** A place to stay, help with a move, company for a difficult conversation.

> *You don't need to rescue them. You need to be the place they can come back to.*

WHEN THERE'S DANGER

If there's violence, threats or real fear, safety comes first. Domestic abuse and victim support helplines also support people who want to help someone else — look up the one in your country. In immediate danger, call your local emergency number (**911** in the US, **112** in Europe, **999** in the UK).

AND YOU

Helping someone who's trapped is tiring. Here too, you have the right to boundaries (Chapter 22): you can be available without being available all the time. Look after your energy so you can keep going.

You now know how to see, respond, set boundaries, leave and help. What's left is the part that turns all of this into a reflex: training. That's Chapter 25.

USE THIS

PROTECT YOURSELF	When you notice something isn't right with someone and you think “someone will say something”, remember the 31%. That someone is you.
HELP SOMEONE	Pick one open question from this chapter and keep it for the next time a friend tells you something that worries you. Ask it, then listen, without giving your opinion.

TODAY'S PRACTICE

Think of someone who once seemed trapped in a relationship — romantic, a friendship or at work. Write down an open question you could ask them, without judgement. If it still makes sense, ask it this week.

EPISODE 24 · RUI

One Sunday afternoon, Inês runs into Rui on the stairs, with shopping bags. This time, he's the one who stops.

“Sorry to butt in. Two years ago, my neighbour on the third floor, Beatriz, worked at your agency. Sofia used to come here a lot. At first they were inseparable.” He pauses. “After a year, Beatriz didn't talk to anyone. Not even her family. One day she moved to Coimbra and I never heard from her again. I never said anything to her. I thought it was none of my business.”

He puts the bags down. “I didn't want to do the same with you. Can I just ask you one thing? How do you feel after you've been with her?”

How many episodes did it take Rui to speak?

CHAPTER

25

The 7-Day Calibration Protocol

Berlin, the early 1990s. At the city's music academy, psychologist Anders Ericsson and colleagues ask young violinists to reconstruct, year by year, how much time they'd spent practising since childhood. They compare the ones their teachers considered the best with the ones who were merely good.

The difference wasn't in initial talent, or in hours spent with a violin in hand. It was in the type of training: the best had built up far more hours of what Ericsson called **deliberate practice** — training focused on one thing at a time, with a clear goal and feedback (Ericsson, Krampe & Tesch-Römer, 1993).

Reading people is the same. It doesn't improve with reading. It improves with deliberate practice.

WHY THIS MATTERS

Remember the first number in this book: on average, we're right 54% of the time when we try to detect lies (Chapter 1). And the second: from 30 seconds of silent video, strangers already rate people almost as well as those who've known them for months (Chapter 4). In other words: you already read people — just without a method or training.

The protocol in this chapter does exactly what Ericsson described: **one channel at a time, with a goal, and with confirmation at the end**. Without it, this book becomes information you forget in two weeks. With seven days, it becomes reflex.

DAY 1 — BASELINE

Pick three people you talk to today. For each one, note: speech pace, gestures, eye contact. Just the normal (Chapter 2).

DAY 2 — NO SOUND

Watch 10 minutes of an interview with the sound off. Note expressions and posture changes. Then watch with sound and compare (Chapter 3).

DAY 3 — THE FEET

All day long, look only at the feet of people in conversation. Who wants to stay? Who wants to leave? (Chapter 4)

DAY 4 — THE WORDS

In a conversation, count: questions answered with questions, "honestly", long explanations for simple questions (Chapter 5).

DAY 5 — THE ROOM

At a meeting, dinner or group, identify the Alpha, the Shadow, the Performer and the Observer in the first two minutes (Chapter 7).

DAY 6 — THE TRIGGERS

Notice every time someone tried to influence you today — ads, colleagues, family. Which trigger did they use? (Chapter 16)

DAY 7 — YOU

Today, watch yourself. When did you feel uncomfortable? What gestures did you make? What words did you use to dodge a topic? Remember your open doors (Chapter 8). People who know themselves read others better.

> *After seven days, you won't read everyone. But you'll stop not seeing.*

AFTER THE 7 DAYS

Repeat the protocol once a month. It's Ericsson's rule: what counts isn't the number of hours, it's the quality of the practice. Each time you'll notice faster and more accurately.

USE THIS

PROTECT YOURSELF	Set a phone reminder now for the first day of every month: “7-day protocol”.
HELP SOMEONE	Do the protocol with someone — a friend, a sibling, your partner. Comparing what each of you saw in the same situation is the feedback Ericsson said was essential.

TODAY'S PRACTICE

Start Day 1 today. Three people, three baselines. Write them down.

EPISODE 25 · SEPTEMBER

It's a year since Inês arrived in Lisbon. One quiet night, sitting on the floor like in that first week, she opens the notebook Sofia gave her in November and starts writing, from the beginning, everything she remembers.

The first week. The borrowed charger. Marco, “but that stays between us”. The question about her ex, right there at lunch. Rui on the stairs: “I know it.”

She writes for two hours. When she's done, she reads it all in one go, as if it were someone else's story.

She closes the notebook. She doesn't cry. She just thinks: *it was all here from day one.*

FINAL REVIEW

Take out your sheet one last time, before you turn the page.

Write your final answer: who manipulated Inês? Also write down the three moments in the story that make you sure.

The next chapter has the answer — and the list of every clue, episode by episode. Compare it with what you wrote at the end of Part I. Did you change your mind? Why?

CHAPTER

26

The Answer and the 50 Signs

THE ANSWER

It was Sofia.

If you got it right, notice *why* you got it right: it wasn't one dramatic moment. It was because her signs were small — and they kept repeating. If you pointed at Daniel, you did what the police in Perugia did with Amanda Knox (Chapter 2): you read nervousness as guilt.

Go back with this book's method. The clues were there from the first page of the story.

SOFIA'S CLUES, EPISODE BY EPISODE

- **Episode 1** — "I stay out of the talking behind backs" and, that same morning, Marco's secret. And the question about the ex, at the very first lunch: looking for open doors (Chapters 1 and 8).
- **Episode 2** — Expansive through the whole meeting; silent, phone in hand, at the exact moment Inês is praised. A deviation from baseline with a topic: Inês's success. And right afterwards she asks for the file (Chapter 2).
- **Episode 3** — The "quick, crooked" smile at seeing Inês happy: contempt. And the seed "he looks like he's had a lot of girlfriends" (Chapter 3).
- **Episode 4** — Repeated touches on the arm; Inês moves away, Sofia leans in again. A boundary test. And Rui leaves as soon as she shows up (Chapter 4).

— **Episode 5** — A question answered with a question, “honestly”, a passive voice, a denial without a denial, and the blame turned onto Inês. Five signs in one answer (Chapter 5).

— **Episode 6** — Late-night messages, always about Daniel, and a deleted message (Chapter 6).

— **Episode 7** — The Shadow: eyes go to her when the room laughs, and the boss decides with her behind a closed door (Chapter 7).

— **Episode 8** — Inês is in transition, alone and only weeks into Lisbon: every open door Sofia mapped at that first lunch (Chapter 8).

— **Episode 9** — Every former colleague was “jealous” or “weak”. And three left in one year (Chapter 9).

— **Episode 10** — Gifts, “you're the only one who gets me”, “I've never had a friend like you”. Friendship love bombing (Chapter 10).

— **Episode 11** — “Long-distance friends are like that”, “Daniel doesn't know you like I do”. Carolina drifts further and further away (Chapter 11).

— **Episode 12** — “I never said that” — and the message is there in writing on Slack (Chapter 12).

— **Episode 13** — Leonor praised in front of Inês; the message to Daniel saying Inês is “stressed” (Chapter 13).

— **Episode 14** — Two days of silence, one day of hugs. Repeated (Chapter 14).

— **Episode 15** — Flowers, tears and “I'm going through a horrible time” on the very day Inês pulls back. And Rui on the stairs, who had seen that scene before (Chapter 15).

— **Episode 16** — Reciprocity (“after everything I did”), urgency (“by six”) and Saturday's rooftop (Chapter 16).

— **Episode 17** — “Team effort” in public; “the idea was mine” behind a closed door. And the first version sent through her phone (Chapter 17).

— **Episode 18** — Inês's good news topped by a Sofia story. And the tiredness after every lunch (Chapter 18).

— **Episode 19** — Intense and unpredictable; Inês never knows which Sofia she'll find (Chapter 19).

— **Episode 20** — Closed-door meetings, emails without Inês in copy, and the promotion (Chapter 20).

— **Episodes 21 and 22** — When Inês says no: silence, a midnight message, crying in public. The reaction to the boundary says it all (Chapters 21 and 22).

DANIEL

Daniel was nervous, turned up late, looked away. He seemed suspicious for half the book. But look at the pattern:

— **The lateness** happened once, with an explanation — noise, not pattern (Chapter 1).

— **The averted gaze** was his baseline, on every topic (Chapter 2).

— **He always answered questions with a straight "no"** and short sentences (Chapter 5).

— **He offered proof** without being asked (Chapter 6).

— **He accepted every one of Inês's "no"s** the first time (Chapters 10 and 22).

— **He remembered the cat from September** (Chapter 19).

Scary signs, in isolation. Good signs, repeated. He was the opposite of Sofia.

RUI

Rui was the Observer from Chapter 7. He saw it from the first day — "I know it" — and kept quiet for almost a year, like the 69% of Darley and Latané's participants (Chapter 24). When he finally spoke, he asked the

right question. It's the last lesson of the story: **seeing isn't enough. Someone has to say it.**

> *The most dangerous person in the story was the one Inês described, at the end of her first week, as: "I already have a friend."*

THE 50 SIGNS ON ONE PAGE

Remember: no single sign proves anything. Look for patterns, consider the context, ask questions.

READ (1–15)

1. A gap between what they say they are and what they do
2. A sudden change from baseline
3. Three deviations tied to the same topic
4. Contempt — one corner of the lip
5. A mouth-only smile
6. A face that contradicts the words
7. Pressed lips
8. Feet pointing at the exit
9. Hands that disappear on a specific topic
10. A gesture that arrives after the word
11. A long pause before a simple answer
12. Too many explanations
13. "Honestly", "I swear", "why would I lie?"
14. Answering a question with a question
15. Messages that shrink and replies that take longer, for weeks

PREDATORS (16–30)

16. Accelerated intimacy
17. “Soulmates” within days
18. A future planned before the present exists
19. Discomfort with your “no”
20. “Your friend is jealous of us”
21. Conflict every time you go to see other people
22. You see your friends less and less
23. “I never said that” when they did
24. You apologise without knowing why
25. A third person always present in conversations
26. You always feel compared
27. Silence as punishment
28. A rollercoaster of affection and coldness
29. Your mood depends on theirs
30. They come back with nostalgia just as you're recovering

POWER (31–40)

31. An unrequested favour followed by a big request
32. A small “yes” growing into a big “yes”
33. “Everyone's already agreed”
34. Artificial urgency
35. Important agreements made only verbally
36. Strategic praise followed by a request
37. A relative who uses guilt as a tool
38. A friend who competes with your good news

39. Interest only when they need something
40. Routine and privacy changing at the same time

DEFENCE (41–50)

41. Decide without pressure — “I'll let you know tomorrow”
42. Don't justify a “no”
43. The broken record against persistence
44. Write down what happens, with dates
45. Keep two people you tell everything to
46. Boundaries with a consequence — and keep them
47. Access is earned with time, not intensity
48. Judge the average, not the peaks
49. Decide today what you'll do if the person comes back
50. Be more alert — not more suspicious

Final Words

Reading people isn't a superpower for controlling others. It's a shield.

People who learn to see stop being easy prey. They stop giving access to people who haven't earned it. They stop confusing intensity with love, confidence with competence, urgency with opportunity.

But watch the other side: people who learn to see can also start seeing too much. Not every pause is a lie. Not every compliment is manipulation. Not every reserved person is hiding something. Remember Daniel. The goal isn't to distrust everyone. It's to **see clearly** — and decide calmly.

And remember Rui. Seeing isn't enough. Sometimes, the most important thing you'll do with this book is ask someone you love a question.

> *Read people before they read you. Then use what you see to protect the people you love.*

— LEGENDCHIL

Instagram @legendchil · TikTok @legendchil

Sources and Further Reading

The cases and concepts in this guide come from published research, books and documented reporting. Inês's story is fiction. For anyone who wants to go deeper:

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This guide is educational. It does not replace psychological, medical or legal advice. Behavioural signs don't prove intentions and must not be used to diagnose anyone.